

A LABORATORY OF DOUBT AGAINST AUTOMATIC BACH

Relearning the French Overture at the Piano



Daniel Porcel Chalup
MMus2
Royal Academy of Music

INTRODUCTION

The Origin of the Project

When Familiar Answers Become Questions

A pianist can make a surprising number of automatic decisions without noticing what sort of decisions they are. The upbeat receives the customary separation before the new section; a repeated phrase or passage acquires a piano or pianissimo dynamic; a strong cadential point is prepared and given time to announce its importance. Even the end of a movement may come with a theatrical flourish of the hands and an exaggerated upward glance. The hands and the body, in a way, simply know what to do at these moments, and the ear, having heard something similar a thousand times, offers little objection. Only afterwards - if that moment ever comes - does the inner musical inquisitor emerge with the awkward question: why did I play it that way?

This project began when that question became difficult to dismiss.

During my conservatoire training, repertoire demands and deadlines rarely left room for prolonged deliberation on such matters. There was always another piece to learn, another concert to prepare, and another apparently indispensable piece of advice to absorb. Intuition and familiar solutions to everyday musical questions were useful companions under these circumstances. They helped me work through the music more quickly and often produced results that sounded convincing, or at least convincing to my ears. Yet I gradually began to wonder whether these companions were making rather too many decisions on my behalf, and whether my ears had grown too accustomed to their answers.

I could play a phrase in a way that sounded right to me and still struggle to explain the choice. A gesture I had used in another piece might also suit the harmony and direction of this one. At the piano, I did not always stop to ask how I had arrived at it.

I have provisionally called such decisions automatic, in spite of a better word, however, the word requires some care indeed. A familiar action is not necessarily an unthinking one, and a musician does not become more perceptive merely by supplying a verbal explanation for every movement of the fingers. Rink's account of informed intuition recognises that experience and knowledge can

enter a performance without presenting themselves as explicit analysis.¹ My concern was with those moments when a useful habit ceased to respond to the passage before me and became a ready-made answer. An answer may be perfectly respectable and still belong to a different question.

Bach's *Ouverture nach französischer Art*, BWV 831, gave this concern a musical setting, a place to explore, a laboratory of doubt. Some of the recordings I listened to left me dissatisfied. I admired the work's scale and imagined considerable variety in its rhetoric, sonority and movement, yet I sometimes heard an approach that seemed more predictable than the music suggested to me. This was my response to particular recordings, not a verdict on a whole tradition for sure. Nevertheless, dissatisfaction is occasionally useful: it obliges us to explain what we expected instead.

What, then, had I expected? Something drawn from the score? From my understanding of French style? Or from the collection of inherited rules, sounds and gestures that my education had taught me to recognise as belonging to Bach?

The title made these questions especially inviting. After the French manner seemed to ask for something more particular than a generally respectable Baroque manner. French music and dance were part of the culture Bach encountered within German-speaking territories, as Norell discusses through the connections with Lüneburg, Celle and French court culture.² But a historical connection, however illuminating, cannot place the pianist's fingers on the keys. It does not settle the length of an upbeat, the balance of two voices or the amount of tempo fluctuation a phrase can bear. Somewhere between the historical explanation and the sounding result, the player still has to make a choice. Not an easy task.

The recordings therefore became a way of retrospectively examining the resources I possessed at the time, rather limited, as I now recognise, and largely intuitive. With those resources, I explored different tempi, contrasting dynamics and sonorities, varied articulations, breathing points and gestures, while retaining a concern for the music's identity and stylistic character. Some versions persuaded me more than others, but I allowed the less successful takes to remain part of the enquiry. A musical experiment must not be attractive to be informative: an awkward result can sometimes reveal a dependence on familiar gestures more clearly than a successful one.

I chose to record first and do the detailed reading afterwards. The recordings show how I approached the work with the knowledge and habits I already had. Once I had played and listened back, I turned to the books to examine those choices. I was reading with my own performances in mind, including particular passages where I wanted to understand why I had played as I did.

¹ John Rink, "Análisis y (¿o?) interpretación," in *La interpretación musical*, ed. John Rink, trans. Bárbara Zitman (Alianza, 2006; reprint 2011), 55–58, especially 57. The term *automatic* is used descriptively here, rather than as a diagnosis of unconscious processing. The recurrence of a gesture does not, by itself, establish the mental process that produced it.

² Luke Norell, "Interpreting Bach's Overture after the French Manner on the Modern Piano" (DM document, Indiana University, 2014), 11–13.

This gave the later study a particular and interesting purpose. I could examine where my choices corresponded with historical arguments, where they departed from them, and whether those departures retained an artistic justification. It also required a little honesty about chronology. Discovering that I had played something in agreement with an author did not mean that the author had guided my hand. Agreement discovered afterwards is still interesting; it simply tells a different story.

Badura-Skoda's *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard* became central to this reconsideration. His phrase "several possible correct executions" offered a welcome starting point.³ It left room for alternatives without relieving the performer of responsibility for them. Indeed, it made the task more demanding. If several solutions are defensible, I must ask what each one reveals, what it conceals, and why its particular choices make sense in the passage. Having more than one answer does not save us the trouble of listening.

Recording introduced another difficulty. I could admire different qualities in different versions without finding one complete version that contained everything I valued. Gould describes a related discovery in his account of "posttaping reconsideration of performance".⁴ While recording the A-minor fugue from Book I of *The Well-Tempered Clavier*, he produced contrasting takes whose limitations became apparent only during later listening, something that I can now associate with deeply. Combining them allowed him to construct a result that neither complete take had supplied. Editing, in this account, participated in interpretation or (re)interpretation as it were, rather than merely repairing its accidents.

Choosing a recording does not make me lose interest in the takes I left out. I wanted to keep them available so that I could hear the same passage played another way. That is why they appear on the website. Here in the essay, I can explain what I noticed when comparing them and how the reading made me reconsider something I had played. Nelson describes accompanying writing as a way of helping others recognise the research insights in an artistic practice.⁵ Someone watching a video can hear my choices, but cannot necessarily know what I learnt from listening to them afterwards.

The project began, then, with dissatisfaction, including dissatisfaction with the ease of my own answers. It developed into an examination of the grounds of my musical judgement. Some familiar decisions survived that examination; others became less comfortable. Both outcomes matter. The relationship between what I played, what I subsequently learnt and what I now consider defensible is where this enquiry begins.

³ Paul Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, trans. Alfred Clayton (Clarendon Press, 1993), 94.

⁴ Glenn Gould, "The Prospects of Recording" (1966), in *The Glenn Gould Reader*, ed. Tim Page (Alfred A. Knopf, 1989), 337–339; quotation at 338.

⁵ Robin Nelson, *Practice as Research in the Arts (and Beyond): Principles, Processes, Contexts, Achievements*, 2nd ed. (Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2022), 40–42.

Correctness, Knowledge and Musical Judgement

What Makes an interpretation 'correct'?

From a performance standpoint

Of all the words that accompany discussions of interpretation, *correct* perhaps deserves the most careful handling. It appears reassuringly precise. If something is correct, something else must presumably be incorrect, and the troublesome business of choosing between them seems almost settled. Almost; but somebody still has to deliver the verdict. Is it the teacher, the historian, the performer, or the composer? And what happens when the members of this distinguished jury disagree?

Badura-Skoda approaches the question through a conception of performance that extends beyond technical accuracy or the observance of historical conventions. In the preface to *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, he identifies the performer's task as recognising and respecting Bach's musical and intellectual intentions, then communicating them through the resources available to the player. The purpose is the pleasure and spiritual enrichment afforded by experiencing the music. This leads him to a comparison that may be uncomfortable for those of us who have invested considerable time in becoming professionals: "a truly enthusiastic amateur church choir can sometimes perform Bach more 'correctly' than an ensemble of uninspired professionals".⁶

This resonates with my own understanding of music-making. A performance may satisfy a considerable number of technical and stylistic requirements while failing to communicate the sense of conviction that made those requirements worth attending to. The amateur choir in Badura-Skoda's example has not necessarily discovered a superior ornament table. Its advantage lies elsewhere.

Badura-Skoda has hardly given us permission to close the books and rely on enthusiasm. On that same page, he argues that knowledge can enrich intuition and inspiration, and wants his book to connect scholarship with practical playing. I find that encouraging. There are things I can learn which will help me hear and play a phrase more clearly. The trouble begins when I become so occupied with getting every detail defensibly right that I forget to listen to the result. I could explain

⁶ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, preface, viii.

every ornament and still leave the phrase sounding rather lifeless. At that point, I would need to return to the piano.

Taruskin examines a related difficulty through the idea of “consulting the oracle”. His target is the assumption that reconstructing the external circumstances of a work’s original performance necessarily recovers the composer’s intentions and gives the resulting interpretation its authority.⁷ The historical details may be valuable, but the conclusion does not follow automatically. Knowing the circumstances in which music was performed does not establish that every feature of those circumstances expressed the composer’s wishes. Some may instead have represented compromises, limitations or the decisions of other participants.

This also makes it necessary to distinguish *correctness* from *authenticity*. In discussions of historical performance, authenticity may concern the reconstruction of earlier practices. In a different sense, it may refer to an interpreter’s conviction or personal engagement. These meanings should not quietly exchange places whenever one becomes more convenient. A performance can be sincerely felt without being historically persuasive; historical evidence, in turn, does not guarantee that its musical realisation will persuade a listener. Neither criterion can do all the work of the other.

The composer might seem the obvious person to settle matters. Taruskin’s account of Debussy and the pianist George Copeland suggests that even this appeal requires care. Having admired Copeland’s playing, Debussy subsequently questioned his treatment of the opening of *Reflets dans l’eau*. Copeland’s explanation was simply, “Because I feel it that way.” According to the account Taruskin recounts, Debussy felt the passage differently but encouraged Copeland to continue playing it according to his own feeling.⁸

The anecdote is attractive, although it is not a universal permission slip. Debussy’s response followed his recognition of Copeland as a persuasive interpreter of his music. What interests me is that the composer could acknowledge a convincing realisation without requiring it to reproduce his own preference. His judgement left room for a distinction between how he would play the passage and how another musician might legitimately make it speak.

Nor does a composer’s recorded performance necessarily provide a single, stable answer. Taruskin points to differences between Stravinsky’s recorded tempos, as well as discrepancies between those performances and the indications in his scores. He also discusses departures from notation in

⁷ Richard Taruskin, “On Letting the Music Speak for Itself,” in *Text and Act: Essays on Music and Performance* (Oxford University Press, 1995), 55.

⁸ Taruskin, “On Letting the Music Speak for Itself,” 54. With characteristic irony, Taruskin describes Copeland’s appeal to feeling as the performer’s familiar answer, “calculated to make any musicologist see red”. Debussy, however, appears to have received it with rather less alarm. Once Copeland’s credentials as an interpreter of his music were established, Taruskin explains, the composer accepted his performances as no less authoritative than his own. Debussy thus appears as “only one interpreter among others”: his different feeling for the passage remained a legitimate preference without becoming the final verdict on how another pianist must play it. The encounter is cited through Taruskin’s account.

recordings and piano rolls by Debussy and Prokofiev.⁹ These examples do not, by themselves, tell us why every discrepancy occurred. They do make the instruction to follow the composer rather less straightforward: which manifestation of the composer's authority should take precedence?

For my enquiry, this matters because it challenges the expectation that an interpretation becomes correct once the performer has located a definitive intention and obeyed it. The evidence can contain alternatives and inconsistencies. Even where an intention is reasonably clear, its realisation requires decisions under particular instrumental and acoustic conditions. The composer's presence, whether in a document or a recording, does not remove the interpreter from the process.

Taruskin's wider objection to letting notated music "speak for itself" concerns precisely this unavoidable mediation. Somebody must realise the written symbols, even when that somebody is only the reader imagining their sound.¹⁰ The score remains indispensable, but it cannot perform the convenient trick of bypassing the musician.

Cook provides a useful way of understanding what this participation involves. In *Beyond the Score*, he questions the conception of music as writing whose meaning is already contained in the score and subsequently reproduced through performance. He instead treats live and recorded performance as primary forms of music's existence, through which musical meaning is produced. His intention is to rethink musicology so that performance becomes integral to its account of music.¹¹

Reading can make me notice something I had passed over at the keyboard. I then have to try it and listen: does the phrase move more clearly, and what happens to the voices around it? Cook's discussion of historically informed performance also gives historical study a less restrictive role. It can show that the familiar way of playing is itself a style, with its own conventions. Once I hear it that way, I have a choice to make. Something I had taken for granted now needs a reason.

I recognise that this discussion produces more questions than a simple definition of correctness would answer. That is part of its purpose. There are limits to what a performance can claim: the notation, the sources and the musical context cannot be made irrelevant merely because an interpreter feels strongly. But those limits require interpretation, and the weight assigned to particular criteria can vary with the context and the nature of the claim.

I can easily imagine listening back to a phrase and saying, 'Yes, that is how it should go.' But why? Perhaps the timing makes the cadence clearer, or I simply like the sound. I want to get better at explaining what persuaded me before calling it correct. If I go further and claim that the choice follows Bach's practice, I need something from the sources to support it. My ear cannot supply that

⁹ Taruskin, "On Letting the Music Speak for Itself," 53.

¹⁰ Taruskin, "On Letting the Music Speak for Itself," 52–55.

¹¹ Nicholas Cook, *Beyond the Score: Music as Performance* (Oxford University Press, 2013), 1–3. Cook's criticism concerns the disciplinary orientation towards music as writing. He explicitly acknowledges the overlap between musicological research and practical performance experience.

evidence, however pleased it may be with the result. Listening to the alternatives gives me a chance to question that first reaction and decide what I would keep, change or try again.

Informed Interpretation

What Knowledge Can (and Cannot) Decide

But when we speak of an informed interpretation, what do we actually mean? Part of the task is to recognise relationships between passages that share musical characteristics and to consider whether an understanding gained in one place can illuminate another. Those relationships may concern style, rhythmic character, fingering, expressive intention or declamation. Recognising them requires close study of the score, historical sources, analytical understanding and practical experience; deciding what to do with them requires comparison and judgement. I still have to play beyond the bar I have been studying. Giving a note a little extra time may sound pleasing until I hear how it interrupts the rest of the phrase. Repeating that gesture elsewhere might help the listener recognise a connection, although I could also end up drawing attention to my favourite way of playing. Knowing more about the details gives me more to consider when I listen to the whole passage. It involves understanding their relationships and weighing their relevance. As Badura-Skoda writes, “the application of knowledge is not inimical to intuition and inspiration”.¹² Knowledge can enrich the performer’s imagination by giving it more to work with.

Bach himself gives us a good deal to study here. He returned to his music and changed details of notation and ornamentation. Comparing the versions lets us see what he reconsidered. Badura-Skoda suggests that these revisions can also teach the performer: Bach sometimes makes an intention clearer, or shows how freely a line can move while keeping its underlying framework.¹³

When Bach writes out an elaboration that might otherwise have been left to the performer, he gives us something concrete to examine: how additional movement arises from the underlying music, where it is introduced and what it contributes to the phrase. Such examples can become models for approaching comparable passages. Before borrowing an elaboration, I need to look at what Bach is doing around it. What allows the extra notes to fit here? Where is the phrase going? His example gives me something I might not have thought to try. I then have to examine the passage where I want to use it; a figure that works beautifully in one place cannot be expected to look after itself everywhere else.

¹² Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, preface viii. The passage explicitly presents knowledge as an enrichment of intuition and inspiration; it does not equate historical information alone with successful performance.

¹³ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, preface xi. His account connects Bach’s revisions, alternative notation and ornamentation with possibilities for interpretation within a defined framework. The pedagogical significance is presented here through Badura-Skoda’s reading of that evidence.

A particularly clear example is the Sarabande from the English Suite No. 2 in A minor, BWV 807, together with its *Les agréments de la même Sarabande*. The coexistence of a simpler version and an ornamented one allows us to observe how the same music can receive a different elaboration without losing its identity. Bach gives the performer more than an abstract invitation to ornament: he provides a concrete realisation that can be studied and compared. Badura-Skoda regards these *agréments* as “masterly models of an art that should also be applied to other, similar pieces”.¹⁴ The implication for an informed interpretation is to recognise what makes the elaboration work and when a similar procedure might be appropriate. The written formula provides a starting point for musical judgement; it does not replace it.

Figure 1a. J. S. Bach, English Suite No. 2, BWV 807, Sarabande, bars 1–11: the less ornamented version.



¹⁴ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, 476. The author interprets the *agréments* as models for elaborating similar pieces and argues that Bach expected comparable improvisatory activity from performers. His reconstruction of that expectation is distinguished here from the documented existence of the written versions.

Figure 1b. J. S. Bach, English Suite No. 2, BWV 807, “Les agréments de la même Sarabande,” bars 1–9: the ornamented version.¹⁵



Look at bar 2. The upper voice's opening crotchet becomes four semiquavers in the *agréments*. The minim that follows stays where it was. Bach has made the first beat busier, leaving the longer note available for repose. The ornamented line still has somewhere to settle. Bars 5–7 show a more extensive elaboration of the upper line, while the bass largely preserves the underlying framework. What Bach supplies is a demonstration of how this kind of movement can be introduced and shaped within a movement established musical structure. A pianist can learn from these relationships without borrowing the figures indiscriminately whenever a similar note value appears. Their appropriateness elsewhere depends on the harmony, the position within the phrase and the character of the surrounding music. Bach's example supplies material for comparison rather than a universal ornament dispenser.

At this point, however, three different kinds of claim need to be distinguished. The existence of a written elaboration is evidence preserved in the musical text. Badura-Skoda's recommendation to study it as a model is a scholarly and interpretative judgement. The proposition that Bach expected performers to elaborate other passages similarly is a reconstruction of historical practice.¹⁶ These claims can support one another, but they do not carry identical degrees of certainty. An informed performer needs to recognise when a source records an instruction, when an author recommends a solution and when the available evidence permits an inference.

¹⁵ Johann Sebastian Bach, English Suite No. 2 in A minor, BWV 807, Sarabande and “Les agréments de la même Sarabande,” in *Englische Suiten I*, ed. Rudolf Steglich (Munich: G. Henle Verlag, 1971), 29–30, bars 1–4.

¹⁶ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, 476. His statement “I do not doubt that J. S. Bach also expected this kind of improvisation from his performers” expresses his conviction about historical practice. The distinction between the surviving written examples and the expectation inferred from them is the argument developed here.

In the French Suites, Schulenberg points out that some surviving versions have more ornament signs than others. A copy with fewer signs may still have been played with ornaments that a musician knew to supply. That possibility changes how I read an apparently plain passage. I would want to consider what the notation leaves to the player before taking its simplicity literally. Schulenberg writes that “it seems likely that Bach expected” such ornamentation, then continues with “If so”. I need to keep that qualification when drawing on his argument. He offers a reason to consider adding ornaments; he has not uncovered an instruction from Bach telling me exactly what to add.

The opposite difficulty also arises: detailed notation does not make every interpretative question transparent. Neumann notes that apparently comparable ornaments can be represented through ordinary notes or through symbols, leaving the performer to ask whether the difference was intentional and whether it entailed a difference in execution. He doubts that a single key can resolve every such case.¹⁷ Bach’s care as a composer therefore gives us reason to examine his notation closely, without requiring us to assume that it operates with absolute consistency. The admiration is entirely compatible with the scrutiny.

A particularly telling example appears in Schulenberg’s discussion of the Sarabande from the Sixth French Suite. Different ornament signs survive in copies made by two of Bach’s pupils, and Schulenberg states that it is impossible to determine which set represents the composer’s notation; he nevertheless finds both musically effective.¹⁸ Here the historical and artistic questions remain distinguishable. Musical persuasiveness cannot settle the attribution of a reading. Uncertainty about attribution, equally, does not prevent the performer from examining what either reading accomplishes. Knowledge clarifies the grounds on which a choice can be defended, including the grounds on which it cannot.

This also explains why an informed approach to BWV 831 benefits from acquaintance with music beyond the piece itself, and beyond the keyboard repertoire. Badura-Skoda recommends comparison with marked passages in keyboard, chamber and orchestral music, as well as the underlay of words in vocal works.¹⁹

The keyboard score is part of a larger musical language. Familiarity with that language can make a detail intelligible that, considered in isolation, appears merely puzzling.

¹⁷ Frederick Neumann, *Ornamentation in Baroque and Post-Baroque Music, with Special Emphasis on J. S. Bach* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1978; third printing with corrections, 1983), 6. His discussion concerns the difficulty of deciding whether differences between ordinary-note and symbolic notation imply differences of execution.

¹⁸ Schulenberg, “Versions of Bach,” 118. He identifies different ornament readings in pupils’ copies of the Sixth French Suite’s Sarabande, distinguishes uncertainty about their attribution from their musical effectiveness, and does not establish either as the uniquely authoritative reading.

¹⁹ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, 94. The reference supports his comparative method across repertoires; it does not establish a specific historical connection between every work discussed here.

An informed interpretation of BWV 831 benefits from looking beyond the keyboard repertoire. The Orchestral Suite in B minor, BWV 1067, offers a particularly useful reference because its voices are entrusted to different players, allowing us to examine how their separate contributions are coordinated and to consider how comparable relationships might be realised at the piano, where one performer has to do everyone's work without the luxury of blaming the flautist. The comparison gives our decisions a basis in the relationships between parts, rather than merely in what we have learnt to recognise as a "Bach-like" sound. Badura-Skoda's recommendation to compare marked passages across different repertoires supports this wider examination.²⁰

Likewise, Bach's vocal music contributes a different kind of reference. Badura-Skoda invokes "Qui sedes" from the B minor Mass, alongside arias from the Passions and melodic writing for violin, when discussing their broadly flowing cantabile lines.²¹ The relevance of the Mass here is melodic continuity and vocal delivery, rather than its being another French overture. A sung line gives the pianist something concrete to consider: how emphasis, syllabic articulation and breath can coexist with a sustained musical direction. The comparison does not establish a specific instruction for BWV 831, but it makes a general claim such as "Bach should be played detached" considerably harder to maintain without qualification.

The examples below bring together the choral melismas of the *Cum Sancto Spiritu* from the B minor Mass and the flowing contrapuntal writing of the Overture. Their affinity offers the pianist a useful reference for considering an extended run of notes as a musical utterance, with direction and continuity beyond its individual figures. Knowing Bach's vocal writing therefore informs the choices available at the keyboard: the pianist has no words to sing, but the fingers need not be kept in ignorance of how a voice might phrase.

²⁰ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, 94. His discussion of articulation recommends comparison with marked passages in keyboard, chamber and orchestral music, together with the text underlay of vocal works. The application of this comparative approach to BWV 1067 and BWV 831 is proposed here.

²¹ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, 127, under "Legato." His examples include "Qui sedes" from the B minor Mass, arias from the Passions and the first movement of the Sonata in E major for violin and obbligato harpsichord, BWV 1016. These references support attention to cantabile writing across media; they do not prescribe a uniform articulation throughout BWV 831.

Figure 2a. J. S. Bach, Mass in B minor, BWV 232, 'Cum Sancto Spiritu', bars 41–50: vocal parts and continuo.

The musical score for Figure 2a shows the vocal parts and continuo for J.S. Bach's Mass in B minor, BWV 232, 'Cum Sancto Spiritu', bars 41–50. The score is written for Alto, Tenor, Bass, and Continuo. The lyrics are: 'Cum Sancto Spi - ri - tu in glo - ri - a De - i Pa - tris, a - men, a - men, a - men, cum Sancto Spi - ri - tu in'. The music features a complex melismatic structure with many sixteenth and thirty-second notes.

Figure 2b. J. S. Bach, *Ouverture in the French Style*, BWV 831, opening movement, bars 21–36.²²

The musical score for Figure 2b shows the opening movement of J.S. Bach's *Ouverture in the French Style*, BWV 831, bars 21–36. The score is written for piano and features complex melismatic and instrumental figuration. The music is characterized by rapid sixteenth and thirty-second note passages, often with grace notes and ornaments.

²² J.S. Bach, Mass in B minor, BWV 232, "Cum Sancto Spiritu," bars 41–50; *Ouverture nach französischer Art*, BWV 831, opening movement, bars 21–28. The comparison concerns the continuity of melismatic and instrumental figuration, rather than an assertion of thematic borrowing or identical articulation.

We can place different versions of Bach's works side by side and examine what changes. That is a considerable advantage, even though some music has been lost and the editions cannot tell us everything about how the surviving works were performed. For me, these comparisons make it harder to settle for saying that something sounds "Bach-like". I can look for the passage that suggested the choice and ask what it actually has in common with the one I am playing. The familiar sound then has something more specific behind it, something I can examine and perhaps reconsider.

Even a well-supported analytical observation leaves a further decision to be made. Rink gives a clear example: recognising the importance of a recurring motif may assist the performer, but persistently emphasising every appearance can produce an absurd result. Knowledge of the relationship does not prescribe the amount of audible emphasis it should receive.²³ Cook similarly questions the assumption that understanding proceeds in one direction, from analysis to its execution in sound. His discussion distinguishes a view of musical relationships as a whole from the performer's experience of their unfolding through time.²⁴ A convincing account of the structure still leaves the task of making its successive events convincing to the ear.

An informed interpretation therefore involves a continuing discrimination between evidence, inference, and musical application. It can rule out a misreading, expose a received habit, suggest an alternative or strengthen a choice already made through experience. It also requires restraint in what is claimed: "Bach writes", "this author recommends", "the sources suggest" and "I find this musically persuasive" are different statements. Their differences deserve to remain audible in the argument. The resulting performance is informed to the extent that its choices engage seriously with the available knowledge and acknowledge its limits. Scholarship gives the performer better reasons to decide; the responsibility for the decision remains at the keyboard.

The Performer's Contribution

Historical knowledge leaves the performer with quite a substantial amount of work. Two pianists may read the same sources, recognise the same conventions and disagree about how a passage should sound. More awkwardly, a performance may convince us while disregarding something we have good reason to consider important. Badura-Skoda acknowledges precisely this difficulty when he writes that "Occasionally such 'pseudo-authentic' performances can be totally compelling, as in

²³ Rink, "Análisis y (¿o?) interpretación," 57–58. This paraphrase refers to the consulted Spanish edition. The example demonstrates the limits of translating an analytical relationship into a systematic instruction to emphasise every occurrence.

²⁴ Nicholas Cook, *Beyond the Score: Music as Performance* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), 42–45. Cook questions the unilateral movement from theoretical analysis to performance and distinguishes analytical perspectives from the temporal circumstances of performing.

the case of Glenn Gould”.²⁵ The admission deserves attention. What, exactly, has the pianist achieved when the result persuades us despite our objections?

My acquaintance with this problem began at twelve, although I certainly did not recognise it as a problem then. Hearing Gould’s later recording of the *Goldberg Variations* was a shock. Some variations moved much more slowly than I expected, yet their delivery was theatrical and strongly declamatory. The separated, almost pointillistic touch, with apparently very little pedal, particularly appealed to me. I liked hearing the notes speak so distinctly. Before my professional training, I copied whatever I could of that manner of playing. I even copied something of his way of sitting at the piano, which was probably the least useful lesson available from the recording.

At that age, however, I had a straightforward explanation for my enthusiasm: if Gould could make Bach sound so convincing, he must be doing it correctly. Badura-Skoda is considerably less accommodating. In his discussion of Gould’s C-minor fugue, BWV 847, he recognises the clarity of the performance while objecting to its relationship with what would ultimately be Bach’s intentions.²⁶ Those two judgments can coexist. My difficulty was that I had allowed the first to settle the second without further enquiry.

Clarke’s discussion of listening helps explain how easily that happens. Familiarity with performances develops our expectations, and listeners can disagree sharply about whether an interpretation sounds capricious or inspired.²⁷ Gould’s playing became familiar to me before I had much knowledge against which to assess it. Certain ways of articulating Bach consequently sounded right because I had learnt to enjoy them. That remains a perfectly good reason to enjoy a recording. It is a less satisfactory reason for applying its manner to every piece.

In the French Overture, I often favour a detached touch, particularly in faster movements and when I want a voice to interrupt a passage or come forward. I do not apply it consistently to all the parts. One line may become more prominent while the other continues, and this treatment passes between voices as my attention changes. I enjoy the resulting differentiation. Nevertheless, there are passages in which I have to ask whether I am following the interaction between the voices or giving them an articulation I already like before considering what they are doing.

Rink makes the issue concrete: even a scale or cadence takes its shape from the function the performer understands it to have within its context.²⁸ Cook’s account of meaning emerging through

²⁵ Paul Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, vii.

²⁶ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 93 and n. 3. The example concerns the C-minor fugue, BWV 847, rather than the A-minor fugue, BWV 865, discussed in Gould’s “The Prospects of Recording”.

²⁷ Eric Clarke, “Escuchar la interpretación”, in *La interpretación musical*, ed. John Rink, trans. Bárbara Zitman (Madrid: Alianza Editorial, 2006; reprint 2011), 220–222. Clarke discusses acquired listening expectations and differences in aesthetic evaluation; the account of my childhood listening is autobiographical.

²⁸ John Rink, “Análisis y (¿o?) interpretación”, in *La interpretación musical*, 55–58, especially 55. The consulted chapter is the Spanish translation; its argument is paraphrased here.

performance explains why these decisions actually matter.²⁹ An entry brought forward by articulation is heard in a different relationship to its surroundings. It may very well interrupt, answer or continue something already underway. Gould himself objects to discussing Bach's lines as though their individual treatment could settle the interpretation: "And even if the contrapuntal movement of four voices could be cleansed part by part of all manner of stylistic ills, this would not in itself suffice for a complete realization of Bach's intentions."³⁰ Gould is listening to how the voices build the harmony and carry the piece forward.³¹ I need to remember that when I bring out an entry. I enjoy making the subject clearly audible, particularly with a detached touch, but I can become so occupied with its arrival that I pay too little attention to what the other parts are doing. Once the entry is clear, I still have to hear where the whole passage is going. Otherwise, I may have introduced the subject very well and interrupted the music in the process.

The modern piano gives me considerable control over such relationships. Badura-Skoda discusses playing Bach on it as a form of transcription and rejects the implication that a transcription must be inferior.³² And he cleverly points out that if we were to treat Bach's music as a transcription, then much of our repertoire, from Haydn and Mozart to Chopin and Liszt, would fall inevitably into that category too, as its performance also relies on instruments different from those available to the composers themselves.³³ Among the qualities he places above a particular sonority are "musicality, the understanding and shaping of musical structure".³⁴ This gives adaptation a serious artistic purpose. The pianist has to decide how the instrument's resources help the music make sense.

Norell discusses what happens when BWV 831 moves from a two-manual harpsichord to the piano. A harpsichordist can change manuals to obtain a contrast; at the piano, I have to make that change through my touch.³⁵ I can also bring one voice forward while keeping another quieter, a possibility Badura-Skoda values in playing counterpoint on the modern piano.³⁶ I like having that freedom. Deciding how much to use is another matter. A little more weight may help me hear an answer between the voices. Too much, and I find myself listening only to the part I have chosen to emphasise.

Badura-Skoda's discussion of the A-major fugue, BWV 864, offers a case in which an exaggeration can serve a precise purpose. He describes the first note of the subject as an "explosion", projecting

²⁹ Nicholas Cook, *Beyond the Score: Music as Performance* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), 10.

³⁰ Glenn Gould, "Bodky on Bach", in *The Glenn Gould Reader*, ed. Tim Page (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1989), 30.

³¹ Glenn Gould, "Bodky on Bach", 30–31.

³² Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 172–173.

³³ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 173. His broad use of "transcription" concerns instrumental adaptation and does not necessarily imply alteration of the written pitches or form.

³⁴ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 173.

³⁵ Norell, "Interpreting Bach's Overture", 29–31

³⁶ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 172–173.

its energy across the rest into the following triplet figure.³⁷ Considering Czerny's dynamic markings, which he associates with memories of Beethoven's playing, he writes:

"This is of course an exaggeration from the point of view of the style of Bach, but may in fact be the best way of making it clear to the listener that the subject (especially in later entries) does not begin after the long rest."³⁸

The importance of the example lies in that last observation. The accent helps the listener hear where the subject begins and how it continues through silence. We can therefore discuss what the exaggeration accomplishes, rather than defend it merely because it sounds impressive. Badura-Skoda's confidence about Beethoven's involvement remains his own historical judgment.³⁹ His account of the musical problem gives the pianist something specific to consider.

Accuracy and restraint, meanwhile, have their own difficulties. Quantz compares musical execution with an orator's delivery: the effect depends on how the material is presented.⁴⁰ C. P. E. Bach lists considerable technical accomplishments before warning that "you may not be a clear, pleasant, and expressive keyboard player".⁴¹ Hill recalls a related difficulty in studying Messiaen: the rhythmic precision he had worked to achieve sounded mechanical to the composer.⁴² These passages concern different repertoires and circumstances, but they each require the performer to attend to what the execution communicates. They also give me a reason to question my preference for briskness. Getting through a passage quickly does not explain its character.

I often like to take faster movements briskly, and part of my exploration of the French Overture involved slowing them down well beyond what I would normally allow myself. At the piano, this could feel dreadful. The movement seemed to take an eternity, and I sometimes felt that I was killing the music. Listening afterwards was a rather different experience. Several versions which had felt uncomfortable while I played them gradually became attractive to me.

The clearest example is the *Passepied* version labelled 4 on the website. I took a much slower tempo and played *pianissimo*, a combination which initially seemed to deprive the movement of two things I enjoyed: speed and brilliance. I also tried the more assertive, brilliant version. Yet I kept returning to the slower one. My discomfort during the take had been quite real; it simply did not tell me reliably how the performance would sound when I was no longer responsible for producing it.

³⁷ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 174, example 6.2.

³⁸ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 174, examples 6.2–6.3.

³⁹ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 174. The connection between Czerny's markings and Beethoven's playing is presented as Badura-Skoda's conviction, rather than as an independently verified reconstruction of a particular performance.

⁴⁰ Johann Joachim Quantz, *On Playing the Flute*, chap. XI, "Of Good Execution in General in Singing and Playing", §§1–3, 109–110. The comparison concerns general musical execution rather than a flute-specific mechanism.

⁴¹ Carl Philipp Emanuel Bach, *Essay on the True Manner of Playing the Clavier*, Part I, trans. Tobias Plebuch, ed. Mark W. Knoll, chap. 3, "On Performance", §1, [Packard Humanities Institute](https://www.packardhumanitiesinstitute.org/bach-essay-on-the-true-manner-of-playing-the-clavier), accessed 25 July 2026.

⁴² Peter Hill, "De la partitura al sonido", in Rink, *La interpretación musical*, 158. Hill reports his own encounter with Messiaen; the application to my playing of Bach is a comparison developed here.

I approached the Sarabande similarly, although I already tend to play it slowly. I tried taking it further than felt comfortable. Comparable experiments in the fugue and Gigue were less effective. I would be reluctant to turn these experiences into a general recommendation to slow Bach down. Their interest is that they unsettled preferences I had stopped examining. Some alternatives brought a freshness I had not anticipated; others gave me little reason to abandon my earlier choice.

Eco distinguishes between interpreting a completed work in different ways and performing a composition that leaves its organisation partly for the performer to determine.⁴³ My experiments with BWV 831 belong to the first case: I keep Bach's written organisation and try different ways of playing it. De Assis's discussion of performance encourages me to question conventions I have inherited, including choices I usually make without much hesitation.⁴⁴ For me, that means allowing an experiment to reach the recording even when I suspect I will dislike it. I do not have to keep the result as my preferred performance. Having heard it, though, I know rather more about why I would reject it.

These texts help me reassess my recordings; they cannot firmly certify my preferred *Passepiéd* as a correct one. I simply liked the slower, quieter version, despite finding it quite uncomfortable to play. Its appeal though, depended on what I made of the tempo, touch and balance: the performer supplies precisely what a recommendation on the page cannot let us hear. In this case, I needed the recording to appreciate my own contribution. The pianist was, for once, the last to be convinced.

⁴³ Eco, "La poética de la obra abierta", páginas digitales 32–34 y 43–44

⁴⁴ De Assis, *Logic of Experimentation*, 19–22

2

French Style and the Musical Identity of BWV 831

Imagining France Bach's World and My Own

France occupies a familiar place in the artistic imagination of every musician. Painting, architecture, dress, conversation and music seem to gather around its name, each contributing something to an expectation of taste. It certainly occupied that place in mine. Bach's French Overture made the association more particular: here was a work that announced a national manner in its published description. Before deciding what that manner meant to me, however, there was another encounter to understand. Bach had already approached France through a German scope.

It is also well known that the French language, fashions and manners enjoyed considerable prestige among the privileged classes of the German territories during Bach's lifetime.⁴⁵ Little and Jenne describe German courts importing French culture as part of their efforts to establish centres of elegance and cultivation.⁴⁶ This gives the musical reference a setting beyond the keyboard. French music belonged to a culture in which speaking, moving and presenting oneself could all demonstrate that one understood how things were done.

Behind this appetite for French elegance lay a rather less elegant history. Little and Jenne begin their account with a Germany still recovering from the Thirty Years' War when Bach was born in 1685. In their reading, the reconstruction extended throughout his lifetime, while courts and cities imported

⁴⁵ Henning Düwell, "La vie quotidienne comme objet de l'enseignement/l'apprentissage du français dans les pays allemands au XVIIIe siècle," *Documents pour l'histoire du français langue étrangère ou seconde* 6 (1990): 157.

⁴⁶ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 1–2.

French and Italian culture in a competition to establish themselves as centres of cultivation.⁴⁷ The fine manners therefore had work to do. They helped a court present itself as somewhere worth admiring, and preferably somewhere more admirable than its neighbour. This makes the French reference in Bach's world considerably more substantial than a preference for attractive decoration: it belonged to the ways in which communities rebuilt and displayed their standing. Its reach also extended beyond the palace. Little and Jenne describe middle-class participation in French-style balls and weekly gatherings organised by Leipzig dancing masters, where the rules of precedence remained firmly in place.⁴⁸ A person could acquire the gestures of court life without acquiring a court; the lessons were rather more affordable than the building. French elegance was consequently something practised in the society around Bach, including by people hoping to improve their position within it.

Bach did not have to travel to France to hear French music. Norell discusses his early encounters with it during his time in Lüneburg, through the French musicians associated with the court at Celle.⁴⁹ I find this a useful starting point for imagining Bach's France: music he could hear and learn from within Germany. His French reference took shape through those encounters, with particular musicians and their ways of playing. Quantz later describes the circulation of musicians between countries and recommends, in some way, selecting the best features, as it were, of all these different styles to form, in the end, a mixed manner he calls German.⁵⁰ His argument does not entirely explain Bach's intentions, but it makes a very useful distinction: learning another style could involve judgement as well as imitation. However, we need to be mindful not to turn that imitation into a caricature and also be aware that of course, as French as Bach wants its overture to be, it will inevitably have some German aspects in it.

Yet its passage through Germany did not automatically mean that its conventions became less French. Johannes Pasch's Leipzig publication of 1705 offers a particularly useful qualification: two of its choreographies preserve the steps and floor patterns of their Parisian counterparts without adaptation to German taste.⁵¹ German reception could include a deliberate fidelity to the imported practice. This gives me a reason to be more exact when describing Bach's French manner through a German lens: the lens could select and combine, but it could also preserve.

⁴⁷ Meredith Little and Natalie Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 3. The account of post-war reconstruction and cultural competition follows the opening of "French Court Dance in Bach's World"; its connection here to the social significance of Bach's French reference is my interpretation.

⁴⁸ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 9–11, especially 11.

⁴⁹ Luke Norell, "Interpreting Bach's Overture after the French Manner on the Modern Piano" (DM document, Indiana University, 2014), 11–12.

⁵⁰ Quantz, *On Playing the Flute*, chap. XVIII, §§86–87, 341. Quantz's discussion supplies a context for the circulation and combination of national styles; the warning against caricature is my own observation.

⁵¹ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 14. Their comparison concerns two choreographies in Pasch's *I.H.P. Maître de Danse, Oder Tantz-Meister* (1705); the qualification concerning German reception is drawn from that comparison, rather than offered as direct evidence of Bach's compositional intentions.

BWV 831 gives this engagement a firm documentary basis. Bach explicitly designated the piece as an overture in the French manner, a description belonging to its publication in 1735.⁵² As opposed to the more familiar titles *French Suites* and *English Suites* have, which have less secure authorial histories.⁵³ With BWV 831, the performer therefore has a particular reason and duty to investigate what this French manner really means and how and why it is portrayed the way it is. The title tells us where to direct our attention, but it does not necessarily tell us that everything we associate with France belongs in the performance.

My visit to France in July 2026 was crucial in clarifying and giving tangible form to the very ‘Frenchness’ I was looking to portray in my rendition of this monumental piece, and therefore in influencing my subsequent recordings. One way of immersing myself while visiting the wonderful palaces and moving through the Louvre was to put the music on through my headphones and begin finding visible counterparts to it in every corner of every room or brushstroke of a painting. I must say that some performances seemed to inhabit what I saw more readily than others, which again raises the question discussed in previous chapters of the real identity of the piece. The rooms and masterpieces made all of those expectations tangible. I could relate to and recognise something of the sound I wanted even before I could explain what produced it.

Figure 3a.⁵⁴



Figure 3b.⁵⁵



⁵² Norell, *Interpreting Bach's Overture*, 4–6.

⁵³ Ullrich Scheideler, “Preface,” in Bach, *French Suites*, iii–iv; and “Preface,” in Bach, *English Suites*, iv–v. The two titles have different documentary histories and should be distinguished from BWV 831's published designation.

⁵⁴ Figure X. Manufacture des Gobelins, after Charles-Antoine Coypel, *Le Bal de Barcelone*, 1732–1736. Wool and silk tapestry, detail. Musée du Louvre, Paris. Photograph by the author, July 2026.

⁵⁵ Figure X. Interior display incorporating panelling from the Hôtel Guimard, Claude Michel, known as Clodion, c.1770–1780. Musée du Louvre, Paris. Photograph by the author, July 2026.

At Fontainebleau, for instance, the extremely decorated ceilings gave the ornaments in the overture a physical presence. The enormous amounts of gold and the intense contrasts between darker surfaces and painted details seemed to correspond to the richness I imagined in the piece. The connection was almost synaesthetic. The distribution of colour seemed as relatable to what I heard in the recordings as the abundance of decoration was to the ornaments in the piece. All these details caught my attention instantly, but mainly because of what surrounded them; their effect depended on their place within the whole.

Figure 4a.⁵⁶

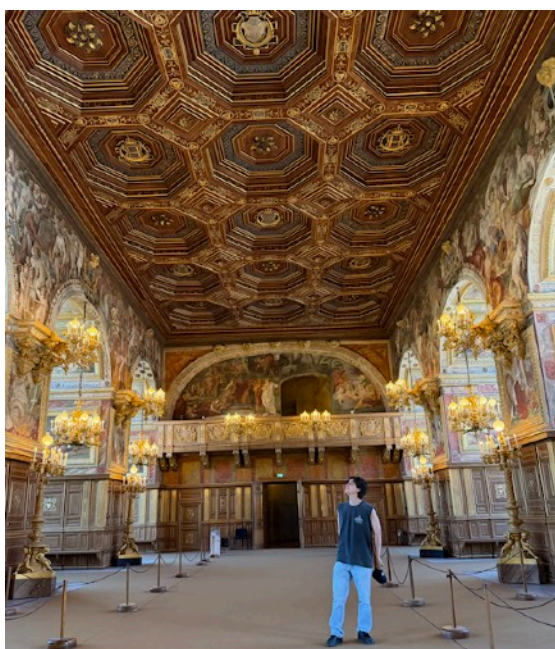


Figure 4b..⁵⁷



This gave me a more useful image of musical ornament than mere abundance for the sake of abundance. An ornament attracts attention without leaving its place within a larger movement or *filo conduttore*, which I associate with Badura-Skoda's discussion of playing the piece as a whole.⁵⁸ This visual association helped me imagine that precise relationship, although the historical justification for a particular execution still belonged to the musical sources. A painted ceiling was an excellent companion to listening, but, at the same time, a somewhat unreliable authority on trills.

The famous Hall of Mirrors at Versailles gave the opening dotted rhythms a different kind of presence: a place where they would actually belong and resonate, rather than remain merely a

⁵⁶ Ballroom, Château de Fontainebleau. Photograph by the author, France, July 2026.

⁵⁷ La Musique, from the tapestry series Les sept Arts Libéraux. Bruges tapestry manufacture, after Cornelis Schut, 1670. Musée du Louvre. Photograph by the author, France, July 2026.

⁵⁸Paul Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, 202.

musical construction of some sort. I could imagine Louis XIV entering to Lully's music, with the room lending weight to the occasion. What struck me was the union between the sound and the space. Together, they seemed capable of making the feeling of this arrival matter more than either could in isolation. This was my imagined scene, rather than a programme I had discovered in Bach's score. It nevertheless clarified what ceremony meant in my own listening. I wanted this experience to carry over into the opening of the overture, for instance, and give its delivery that awareness, rather than allow it to acquire importance merely through a loud chord

Figure 5⁵⁹.



Figure 6a⁶⁰



Figure 6b

Figure 6c.

In the portrait of Marie de Médicis, the splendid dress, jewels and enormous ruff around her neck gave that ceremonial presence a human form. Even her posture seemed to belong to the clothes; there was little room in the whole arrangement for a casual movement. I associated this majestic bearing with the gallantry I imagined in the music, where an elaborate appearance could still be carried by a controlled gesture.

What was being preserved included an unusually demanding idea of ease. Among the ideals Little and Jenne identify are



⁵⁹ Hall of Mirrors, Château de Versailles. Photograph by the author, France, July 2026.

⁶⁰ Figures 6a, 6b and 6c. Royal portraits encountered during the visit: (a) Frans Pourbus II, Marie de Médicis, first quarter of the seventeenth century, Musée du Louvre; (b) Philippe de Champagne, Louis XIII couronné par la Victoire, c.1634, Musée du Louvre; (c) Anonymous French artist, *Louise-Marguerite de Lorraine, princesse de Conti*, first half of the seventeenth century. Oil on panel. Musée Condé, Château de Chantilly, PE 290. Photograph, July 2026.

sweetness, goodness, decency, order and majesty, with nonchalance giving the trained body a relaxed readiness for movement.⁶¹ This is the detail that most usefully qualifies my impressions of the palaces. At Versailles, I could easily imagine a grand entrance, complete with the clothes and the occasion. Little and Jenne's account of nonchalance makes me picture how the person entering might actually move: the bearing is noble, but the body remains relaxed and ready to dance.⁶² I want something of that ease in the overture. The opening loses much of its appeal to me when it sounds uncomfortable in its own splendid clothes. Yet the dancing master's lessons were not welcomed by everyone.

Of course, the following dances offer a more direct historical connection between appearance and musical movement. Little and Jenne describe court balls in which couples danced in an order determined by rank, beginning and ending with formal reverences.⁶³ This immediately involves some sort of hierarchy, and I feel that this must also be translated into the music. In the end music is not really democratic, as some notes are more important than others. All the choreographies were learned in advance, and those watching could recognise whether they were performed correctly.⁶⁴ Grace took place under observation, and particular care was given to learning the gestures, movements and pace that made each dance clearly differentiated and defined. The dancer not only needed to know the movement, but also how to make knowing it look agreeable.

Their account of dancing masters makes the connection still clearer. These teachers instructed courtiers in deportment as well as dancing: how to bow, acknowledge others and manage the details of presenting oneself.⁶⁵ Musical movement belonged to this wider education of the body, since the music was not merely accompanying the dance but directing it. For a pianist, this gives dance character a substance that a tempo marking alone cannot provide. A dance name carries expectations about how movement is prepared, directed and completed, even when there are no dancers in the room.

It also makes the apparent ease of French elegance more interesting. The ease could be learned until its preparation disappeared from view. Couperin offers a practical example at the keyboard: place a mirror on the music desk, he advises, to discourage facial grimaces.⁶⁶ He also recommends "an air of ease" and, for those playing from memory, looking towards the company as though

⁶¹ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 8. The application of their account of *nonchalance* to my impressions of the palaces and to pianistic movement is my own.

⁶² Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 8. The application of their account of *nonchalance* to my impressions of the palaces and to pianistic movement is my own.

⁶³ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 2–3. The application of social hierarchy to musical emphasis is my own interpretative association.

⁶⁴ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 2–3.

⁶⁵ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 4–5. The relationship to pianistic interpretation is my application of their account of dance instruction and deportment.

⁶⁶ Couperin, *L'Art de toucher le clavecin*, 11.

occupied with nothing else.⁶⁷ The fingers may be conducting difficult business; the face need not invite the audience to inspect the accounts.

Couperin's mirror makes me think about how readily I associate visible effort with expression. His comparison between grammar and declamation brings the question back to the keyboard: knowing how to read the notes is still some distance from knowing how to deliver them.⁶⁸ I can look perfectly composed and play an expressive phrase. I can also look deeply moved while doing very little with it. When I call a performance elegant, I want to listen for how the phrase moves, where it breathes and how it arrives. The expression on my face will have to look after itself.

In 1707, Pasch defended French court dancing against pietist criticism, arguing that a well-regulated dance was natural, useful and morally beneficial, while its misuse was another matter.⁶⁹ The cultivated body was thus also a disputed body. That disagreement gives some substance to the tension I sensed between an agreeable appearance and what lies beneath it. In Bach's Germany, the value of these elegant movements was already being argued over. For my reading of BWV 831, the important addition is the responsibility carried by the gesture: it could display rank, demonstrate acquired refinement or invite moral suspicion. A graceful movement might have rather more at stake than looking graceful.

Cowart describes court balls where rank determined one's place, and masked balls at the Opéra where a person could temporarily conceal their identity. The latter still drew largely aristocratic and upper-bourgeois participants; the mask did not suddenly admit everyone to the party.⁷⁰ That gives me a livelier picture of the society behind these dances. People could enjoy a little disguise as well as the ceremony of being recognised. I want to remember that when playing BWV 831. Once I have imagined the grand entrance, I need to leave room for the pleasure and play of the dances that follow. The king cannot spend the entire suite arriving.

⁶⁷ Couperin, *L'Art de toucher le clavecin*, 11. The advice about looking towards the company specifically concerns those playing without their books.

⁶⁸ François Couperin, *L'Art de toucher le clavecin*, ed. Anna Linde (Breitkopf & Härtel, n.d.), "Preface",

⁶⁹ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 14, discussing Pasch's *Beschreibung wahrer Tanz-Kunst* (1707). Pasch's argument is cited through Little and Jenne; the connection to my experience and to BWV 831 is my interpretation.

⁷⁰ Georgia J. Cowart, "The Musical Theater in Watteau's Paris", in *Watteau, Music, and Theater*, ed. Katharine Baetjer (New York: The Metropolitan Museum of Art, 2009), 9–18.



Figure 6.⁷¹

Before David's coronation scene, I definitely felt the enormity of the occasion and how small I was beside it. My figure in the photograph makes that feeling quite obvious. The overwhelming scale gave me another way of imagining musical grandeur, and the feeling of being in the presence of something much larger than oneself.

My visit supplied experiences beyond that historical world. At the Musée Rodin, *The Gates of Hell* and *The Three Shades* unsettled the ease with which agreeable and elegant qualities are usually associated with French art. What held my attention was the tension of the bodies. In my photograph, their discomfort suggested more than physical strain: somehow, it connected to the inner problems of a person within something beautiful, like a façade. Perhaps this helps explain why the French Overture has so much meaning and coherence for me.

⁷¹ Jacques-Louis David, *Le Sacre de Napoléon*, 1806–1807. Musée du Louvre. Photograph by Author, France, July 2026.

Figure 7.⁷²

Chantilly supplied a gentler connection. Walking through its gardens, I associated the *Passepied* II with a quieter, almost green quality of sound. Little and Jenne's identification of its drone bass with the *musette* gives that pastoral impression a musical foundation.⁷³ The particular garden remained my own contribution to the subject, but it is worth noticing that the historical reference and the personal image can support one another without becoming interchangeable.



The quieter movement also prevented my picture of the work from being dominated by Versailles. BWV 831 could suggest an imposing entrance and, elsewhere, a pleasure that required much less public attention. Those different associations made me listen for differences of character within its French reference. The title was becoming more demanding. It gave me something more particular to consider than a general instruction to make Bach sound suitably grand or refined.

Bach's French reference and my experience of France therefore contribute different kinds of knowledge. The sources establish conventions and contexts through which I can examine the musical decisions. The journey helps explain why certain possibilities attracted me in the first place. Together, they allowed me to ask a more precise question of the recordings: whether a performance communicates the character I imagined, and how its means of doing so relate to the French musical manner announced by the work. Versailles helped me imagine an entrance. However, the recording still had to persuade the listener that someone had arrived.

⁷² Auguste Rodin, *The Three Shades*, garden display, Musée Rodin, Paris. Photograph by Author, France, July 2026.

⁷³ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 91.

The Overture

Dotted Rhythm and the Limits of Literal Reading

Having established a broader context for French style, I can now turn to the details through which that style becomes audible. The opening of BWV 831 is an obvious place to begin, although its dotted rhythms are rather less obvious to perform than to recognise. In many of the recordings I had heard, the introduction sounded slow and solemn. I explored that character in my own recordings too, but often missed the more buoyant, lifted quality I associated with the music. I wanted the opening to retain its grandeur without making every gesture feel weighed down by it.

With Bach's crossed C in front of me, I want to feel the bar moving through its two minim beats.⁷⁴ Quantz distinguishes the counting units of *alla breve* from those of common time.⁷⁵ That helps me think about what I am doing between the beats. I still need the crotchets to be clear, but giving each one the same insistence can make the opening feel rather heavy. Badura-Skoda examines the historical evidence for overture tempo and the difficulties of interpreting it.⁷⁶ I have to return to the keyboard to choose my speed: can I give the dotted figures their weight and still feel the next minim beat approaching?

The more immediate difficulty is deciding what the dots mean. Badura-Skoda warns that rhythmic notation in Bach's time cannot always be read according to modern conventions.⁷⁷ In the passages he discusses, a literal modern reading can therefore miss the expected execution. It is an awkward discovery for the conscientious pianist: counting carefully is not quite the same thing as knowing what one is counting.

His example of an upbeat following a rest makes the problem clear. In the notation he discusses, the rest has no dot, yet the following short note belongs much nearer the subsequent arrival than a literal division would suggest. The performed rest is effectively longer and the upbeat shorter. His comparison between the written and realised patterns makes visible a discrepancy that the musician was expected to resolve.⁷⁸

⁷⁴ J. S. Bach, *Französische Overture*, BWV 831, opening movement, time signature and bar 1.

⁷⁵ Johann Joachim Quantz, *On Playing the Flute*, ch. V, §19, 66.

⁷⁶ Paul Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, trans. Alfred Clayton (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1993), 85–89

⁷⁷ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 50–53.

⁷⁸ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 50, ex. 2.63. The account of the rest convention follows his argument, rather than asserting the universal absence of dotted rests throughout all Baroque sources.

Ex. 2.63



Figure 9. Conventional notation and proposed execution of short upbeats following rests.⁷⁹

Quantz gives a particularly useful instruction here. When demisemiquavers follow a long note and a short rest, they are to be delayed until the end of their allotted time and then played rapidly, without losing the beat.⁸⁰ He also describes a semiquaver rest in slow *alla breve* or common time as effectively dotted when dotted notes follow it.⁸¹ This keeps the next beat in place while changing how the short notes approach it.

For me, this provides a relevant comparison for the opening bar of BWV 831 and for the rapid figures in bars 8–10. The rest and the flourish belong to one gesture: leaving more space before the short notes can make their eventual arrival more decisive. The relationship is worth considering in the dotted figures of bars 4–5 too, rather than applying one degree of sharpening throughout the introduction.⁸² In bar 1, prolonging the dotted crotchet and shortening the following quaver would make the long–short relationship more pronounced. How pronounced remains the question. The title provides a stylistic context; it does not print a second dot for us.



Figure 9a. J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Overture, bars 1–2.⁸³



Example 9b. J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Overture,, bars 4–5.⁸⁴

⁷⁹ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 50, ex. 2.63.

⁸⁰ Quantz, *On Playing the Flute*, ch. XVII, section II, §16, 226, fig. 29. This instruction concerns the rapid figures following a long note and a short rest.

⁸¹ Quantz, *On Playing the Flute*, ch. XVII, section II, §16, 226, figs. 30–31.

⁸² Bach, BWV 831, opening movement, bars 1, 4–5 and 8–10; Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 50–55. The proposed application to these passages is the author's comparison, not an assertion that Badura-Skoda discusses every listed bar there.

⁸³ Bach, *Ouverture nach französischer Art*, BWV 831, opening movement, Henle Verlag, bars 1–2.

⁸⁴ Bach, *Ouverture nach französischer Art*, BWV 831, opening movement, Henle Verlag, bars 4–5.



Figure 10. Notated rhythm and proposed execution.⁸⁵

The existence of BWV 831a makes that question more interesting. Norell points to a change we can see on the page: upbeat figures written in semiquavers in the earlier C-minor version become demisemiquavers in the published B-minor version.⁸⁶ What made Bach change them? In the debate Norell recounts, Neumann hears a revised musical idea. Emery reads the shorter values as Bach spelling out more clearly how he already wanted the figures played.⁸⁷

Norell favours the latter, arguing that Bach was communicating the same musical conception more explicitly to the public.⁸⁸ Looking at both versions, I can hear why that explanation appeals to a performer. It still requires an argument: the changed notation shows what Bach altered, but does not explain his reasons.

Schulenberg distinguishes between versions of the compositional text, changes in performing practice during Bach's life, and the later transformation of his music in performance and reception.⁸⁹ His survey lists the Overture among works whose rhythm or rhythmic notation was altered.⁹⁰ That distinction matters here. Before deciding how to play the earlier notation, I need to ask what sort of change I think I am looking at: a different rhythm, a clearer account of the same rhythm, or a mixture of both.

⁸⁵ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 51.

⁸⁶ Luke Norell, "Interpreting Bach's Overture after the French Manner on the Modern Piano" (DM document, Indiana University, 2014), 14–15.

⁸⁷ Norell, "Interpreting Bach's Overture", 15–18

⁸⁸ Norell, "Interpreting Bach's Overture", 18–19. The account of Bach's intention is Norell's argument about the two versions.

⁸⁹ David Schulenberg, "Versions of Bach: Performing Practices in the Keyboard Works", in *The Music of J. S. Bach: Analysis and Interpretation*, ed. David Schulenberg, *Bach Perspectives* 4 (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 2024 open-access reprint), 111.

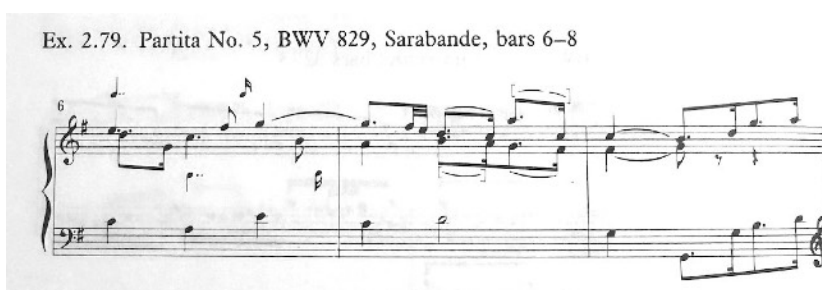
⁹⁰ Schulenberg, "Versions of Bach", 112–113, table 1, especially the distinction between alteration of rhythm and alteration of rhythmic notation in category 7.

I cannot take quite the same instruction from Quantz and C. P. E. Bach. Quantz gives dotted crotchets and minims their ordinary proportional values, then describes sharpening the short notes following smaller dotted values.⁹¹ C. P. E. Bach's instruction to shorten notes after dots is broader, although he makes exceptions for rhythmic coordination, ornaments and affect. He adds: "You need to judge the ideas in which they occur accurately."⁹² That leaves me looking again at the dotted crotchet and quaver in my opening bar. How much should I shorten that quaver? I need to hear what the sharpening does to its approach to the next beat. The advice gives me something to try, and a reason to pay attention to the result.

Badura-Skoda's objection to indiscriminate sharpening is particularly forceful in his discussion of Dolmetsch's proposed execution of the E-flat-minor Prelude from Book I of the *Well-Tempered Clavier*: the result would sound "simply appalling".⁹³ He nevertheless recommends a slight shortening of its upbeat values.⁹⁴ I find the distinction useful. The short note can become more pointed without making the phrase sound as though somebody has taken scissors to it.

The Sarabandes included in my examples make that distinction concrete. In the Fifth Partita, Badura-Skoda compares the figures in bars 6–8 with those in bars 13–16 to support a sharper long-short relationship.⁹⁵ He also proposes dotting the melody of the Fifth French Suite's Sarabande, allowing a more elegant, softer execution.⁹⁶ Yet he argues against changing its middle voice indiscriminately, citing the equal quavers retained in bar 7.⁹⁷ Here the comparison gives me something specific to take back to the Overture: I can examine a figure against a related one, then check what the accompanying voice is doing. The right-hand gesture does not give the left hand an automatic invitation to follow suit.

Figure 11. J. S. Bach, Partita No. 5, BWV 829, Sarabande, bars 6–8.⁹⁸



⁹¹ Quantz, *On Playing the Flute*, ch. V, §§20–21, 66–67.

⁹² Carl Philipp Emanuel Bach, *Essay on the True Manner of Playing the Clavier*, part I, ch. 3, §23, trans. Tobias Pleburch, ed. Mark W. Knoll, Packard.

⁹³ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 55, ex. 2.73. Dolmetsch's proposed execution is discussed through Badura-Skoda.

⁹⁴ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 55. The alternative he proposes is a slight, almost imperceptible shortening.

⁹⁵ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 57–58, ex. 2.78–2.79: BWV 829, Sarabande, bars 13–16 and 6–8.

⁹⁶ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 58–59, ex. 2.80: BWV 816, Sarabande, bars 1–8.

⁹⁷ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 58. His qualification concerning equal quavers in the middle voice at bar 7 relates to BWV 816.

⁹⁸ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 58, ex. 2.79

Figure 12. J. S. Bach, Partita No. 5, BWV 829, Sarabande, bars 13–16.⁹⁹

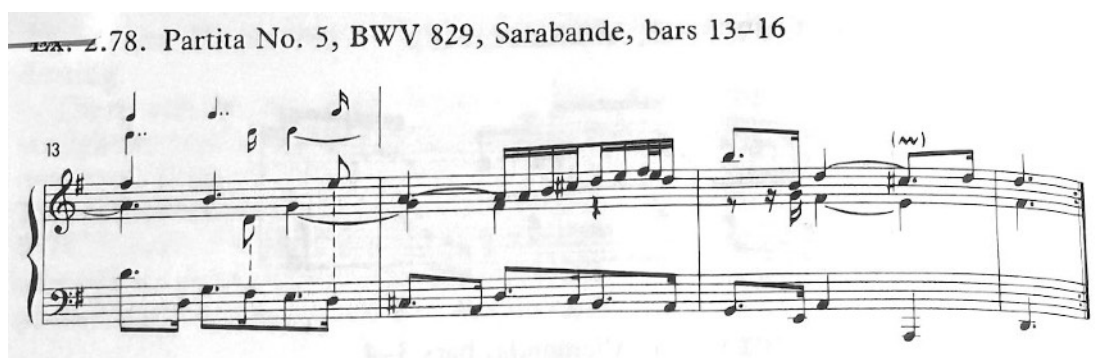
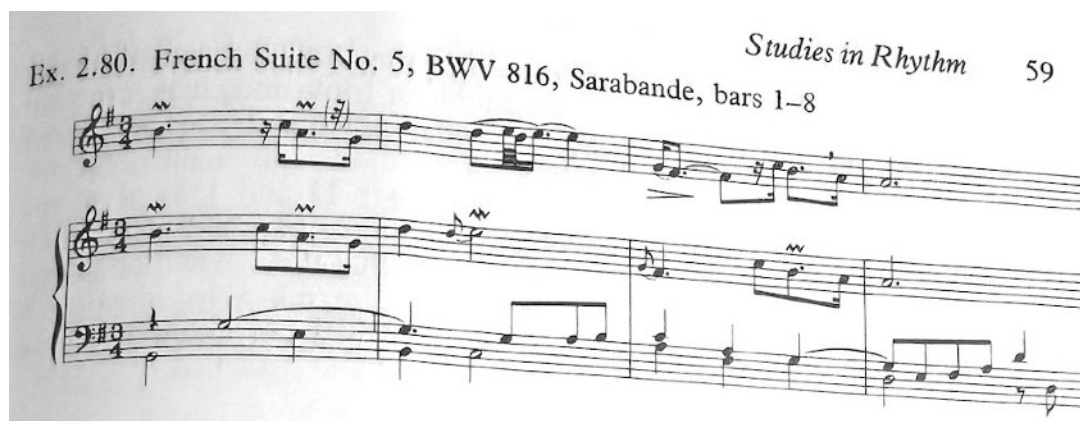


Figure 12a. J. S. Bach, French Suite No. 5, BWV 816, Sarabande, bars 1–8.¹⁰⁰



The edition itself can complicate matters before a pianist has played a note. Badura-Skoda compares the G-minor Prelude from Book II of the *Well-Tempered Clavier* with the opening of the Second Partita's Sinfonia.¹⁰¹ He identifies dotted rests in the Prelude's editions as editorial modernisation of notation in which separate rest values were used.¹⁰² In his paired examples, the newer notation is easier to read, but makes the old convention harder to see. This helps explain the apparently undotted rests I encounter in the Overture. Before treating them as instructions for a longer upbeat, I need to consider the gesture to which that upbeat belongs.

⁹⁹ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 57–58, ex. 2.78.

¹⁰⁰ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 59, ex. 2.80.

¹⁰¹ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 51–52, exx. 2.64–2.66.

¹⁰² Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 51–52. The comment concerns the editions discussed in his 1993 book, rather than all editions currently available.

Figure 13. J. S. Bach, Partita No. 2, BWV 826, Sinfonia, bars 1–2: notation and proposed execution.¹⁰³

Ex. 2.64. Partita No. 2, BWV 826, Sinfonia, bars 1–2

Grave adagio

Original notation:

Execution

Figure 13a. J. S. Bach, BWV 885, Prelude, bars 1–2: the editorial notation discussed by Badura-Skoda.¹⁰⁴

Ex. 2.65. WTC II, Prelude in G minor, bars 1–2 [as in all printed editions]

Largo

Figure 13b. J. S. Bach, BWV 885, Prelude, bars 1–2: the original notation reproduced by Badura-Skoda.¹⁰⁵

Ex. 2.66. WTC II, Prelude in G minor, bars 1–2, Bach's original notation [appears in no printed edition]

Largo

¹⁰³ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 51, ex. 2.64.

¹⁰⁴ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 52, ex. 2.65.

¹⁰⁵ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 52, ex. 2.66.

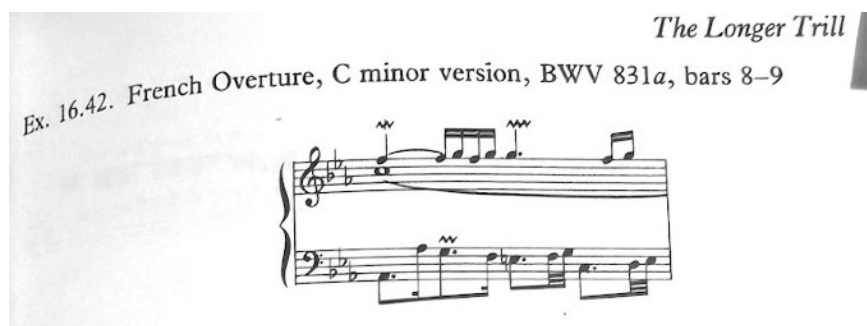
The short rests around a trill introduce another distinction. Here the issue is how the ornament finishes and how its termination approaches the next note. C. P. E. Bach describes the rapid connection of a trill termination and specifies a small separating space in a particular dotted-note context.¹⁰⁶ The gap is proportionate to the tempo and only approximately represented by the notation.¹⁰⁷ For my purposes, the useful detail is the location of that space: it separates the termination from the following note. Moving it elsewhere would change the gesture.

In bars 8–9 of BWV 831, Badura-Skoda draws attention to a small halt and break before the trill's suffix, a treatment he associates with French-style overtures and sarabandes.¹⁰⁸ He also examines the simpler notation in BWV 831a and reads it as evidence for a rapid termination.¹⁰⁹ I am interested in that little space before the final notes. It allows me to hear the suffix as the trill's ending. When I let everything run together, I can lose that ending in the flow, even though I have played all the notes.

Figure 14. J. S. Bach, BWV 831, opening movement, bars 8–9.¹¹⁰



Figure 14a. J. S. Bach, BWV 831a, opening movement, bars 8–9.¹¹¹



¹⁰⁶ C. P. E. Bach, *Essay*, part I, ch. 2, section 3, §13 and §14, trans. Pleburch, accessed 8 October 2026. The small separating space in §14 occurs after the termination and before the following note.

¹⁰⁷ C. P. E. Bach, *Essay*, part I, ch. 2, section 3, §14. Its duration is related to the tempo, and the written representation is approximate.

¹⁰⁸ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 430, ex. 16.41.

¹⁰⁹ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 430–431, exx. 16.41–16.42.

¹¹⁰ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 430, ex. 16.41.

¹¹¹ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 431, ex. 16.42.

The opening of the Fifth French Suite gives the comparison a useful obstacle. In his footnote, Badura-Skoda objects to making the break obligatory: in that cantabile passage it would interrupt the line and produce consecutive fifths.¹¹² He illustrates an alternative execution informed by C. P. E. Bach.¹¹³ I would be reluctant to acquire a new breathing habit only to discover that it makes the next piece hiccup. The Overture's separation therefore needs to be understood through its particular figure, not carried from one trill to another merely because it worked once.

Figure 15. Trill terminations at the opening of BWV 816.¹¹⁴



An execution on the lines suggested by C. P. E. Bach would avoid both these pitfalls:



The question of *notes inégales* finally brings this discussion back to my own playing. Before undertaking this reading, I had some awareness of unequal execution and experimented with it in a take of Gavotte II. The quavers acquired a different flow, approaching a triplet-like long-short relationship. I now have a clearer distinction between that experiment and overdotting. In one case I altered the relationship between notes written as equal; in the other I would sharpen a relationship already written as unequal.¹¹⁵ The detailed consequences for the Gavotte belong with the dances, but the distinction matters here because both procedures can too easily be filed under the same heading of 'French rhythm'.

¹¹² Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 430 n. 17. The written example illustrates his objection to Klotz's proposed universal break before the suffix.

¹¹³ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 430 n. 17, lower musical example. The execution informed by Emanuel Bach is reproduced through Badura-Skoda.

¹¹⁴ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 430 n. 17.

¹¹⁵ François Couperin, *L'Art de toucher le clavecin*, ed. Anna Linde (Breitkopf & Härtel, n.d.), 23; Quantz, *On Playing the Flute*, ch. XI, §12, 123–124. The account of Gavotte II is autobiographical; no fixed 2:1 ratio is prescribed here.

Couperin puts the notational difficulty plainly: “we write a thing differently from the way in which we execute it”.¹¹⁶ He describes French musicians playing some successive quavers unequally while continuing to write them as equal, and concludes that “our custom has enslaved us”.¹¹⁷ That last phrase is particularly apt for my project. The performer who knew the convention could supply something the notation left unsaid. I also supplied things from habit when recording BWV 831; the question now is which passages actually supported them.

Quantz’s discussion of unequal execution excludes, among other cases, very fast passagework, repeated notes on the same pitch and notes bearing dots or strokes.¹¹⁸ Badura-Skoda argues for equal execution of the figures in bars 13 and 158 of BWV 831.¹¹⁹ He compares these with bars 8–9 of the sixteenth Goldberg Variation, where dots mark detached execution and, in his reading, also exclude inequality.¹²⁰

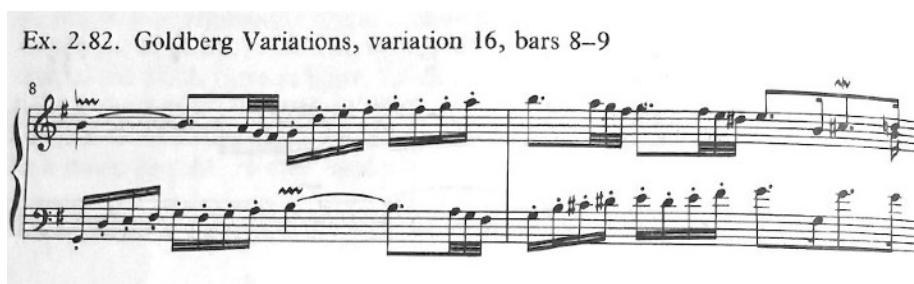
Figure 16 J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Overture, bars 13.¹²¹



Figure 16a. J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Overture, bars 148¹²²



Figure 16b. J. S. Bach, Goldberg Variations, BWV 988, variation 16, bars 8–9.¹²³



¹¹⁶ Couperin, *L'Art de toucher le clavecin*, 23, English column. The quotations follow this edition’s translation, rather than the different English wording in Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 58–59.

¹¹⁷ Couperin, *L'Art de toucher le clavecin*, 23.

¹¹⁸ Quantz, *On Playing the Flute*, ch. XI, §12, 123–124.

¹¹⁹ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 60. Bars 13 and 158 follow his numbering of BWV 831.

¹²⁰ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 60, ex. 2.82. The articulation dots explicitly discussed here belong to the sixteenth Goldberg Variation.

¹²¹ Bach, *Ouverture nach französischer Art*, BWV 831, opening movement, bars 1–2.

¹²² Bach, *Ouverture nach französischer Art*, BWV 831, opening movement, bars 4–5.

¹²³ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 60, ex. 2.82.

Looking at the Goldberg passage, I want to try that equal, separated movement in the comparable runs of BWV 831. The comparison draws on Badura-Skoda's reading of the articulation dots and Quantz's exceptions to unequal execution.¹²⁴ I would listen first to how the run emerges from the dotted figures around it. Can I hear the change clearly? Do the separated notes still lead somewhere? Those are the things I need to hear before keeping the articulation. Studying another work gives me a possible way of playing the passage; I then have to find out what it does here.

I was already playing these runs *détaché* when I came to read this passage. Badura-Skoda's recommendation to keep the values equal in these bars caught my attention.¹²⁵ It gave me something specific to check in the recordings, besides the separation itself. In bar 1, I was listening for something else: the moment when the short quaver finally moves on from the dotted crotchet. I wanted to give the long note enough time to sound imposing, then hear the quaver take me into the next beat. That small movement was important to the opening I had in mind.

The Dances

French Manners and Bach's Exceptions

After the opening Overture, the French style becomes a more particular business. The following dances are familiar from Bach's suites, with the Echo standing apart from the others. The Sarabande, Gavotte and Gigue do not acquire their characters simply by occupying different positions on the metronome but from a more substantial analysis. Little and Jenne distinguish the beat from its subdivisions and explain how these rhythmic levels relate to the dances' articulation, affecting the movement and repose of a phrase.¹²⁶ This gives me something more useful than a simple collection of adjectives. Following these parameters, I could ask where the phrase begins, how I sustain it and whether its apparent ending actually allows the music to find rest.

The Sarabande provides a particularly revealing example. Its familiar second-beat emphasis is easy to recognise, and equally easy to turn into a habit. In Little and Jenne's model, a four-bar phrase reaches its principal repose at the beginning of bar 4; the characteristic second-beat emphasis belongs to patterns within that larger movement.¹²⁷ It would therefore be misleading to describe the dance as four successive bars receiving the same accent. The second beat has a job and a purpose, but it is not the conductor of the entire movement.

¹²⁴ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 60, ex. 2.82; Quantz, *On Playing the Flute*, ch. XI, §12, 123–124.

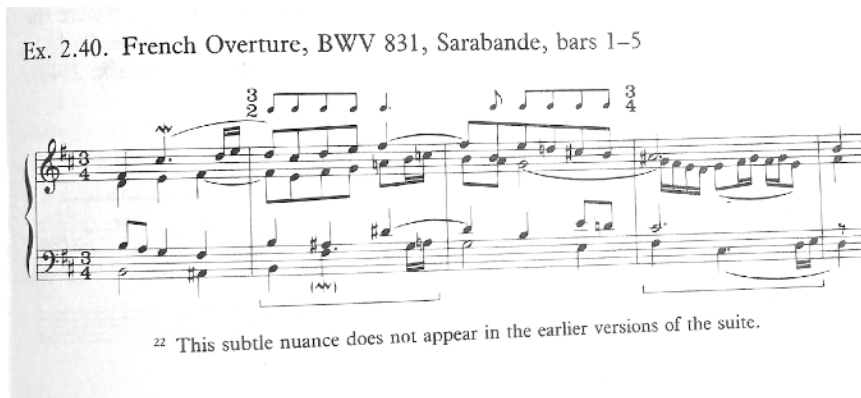
¹²⁵ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 60.

¹²⁶ Meredith Little and Natalie Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1991), 16–21.

¹²⁷ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 96–98, figs. VII-2 and VII-3. Their model places the principal thesis at the beginning of bar 4; it does not prescribe an identical accentuation for every bar of every sarabande.

Figure 17.¹²⁸

Ex. 2.40. French Overture, BWV 831, Sarabande, bars 1–5

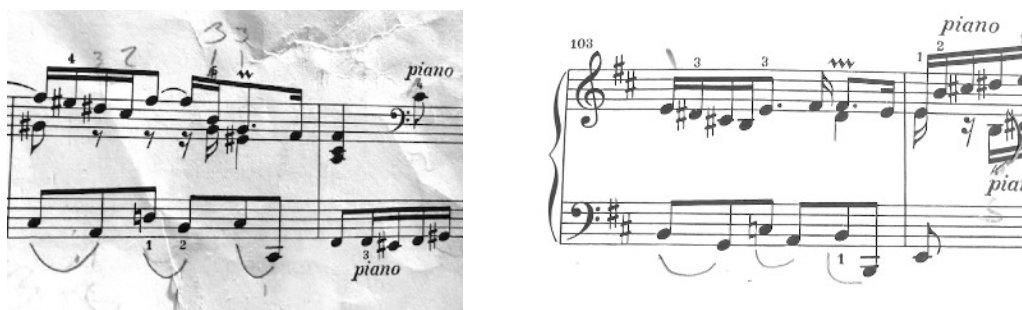


²² This subtle nuance does not appear in the earlier versions of the suite.

In BWV 831, Badura-Skoda identifies a hemiola in the upper and middle voices across bars 2–3. Meanwhile, the lower voice maintains the motion in 3/4 and, in bar 4, the *a*# anticipates the continuation heard in the upper voice in bar 5.¹²⁹ Both organisations need to remain audible. Accenting every voice together would simplify precisely what makes the passage interesting. At the piano, I can bring out the upper voices' longer grouping in twos while also allowing the lower line to retain its own rhythm. The arrival in bar 4 also contains the preparation for what follows; giving it the full ceremony of a conclusion would overlook that continuation. This grouping nevertheless makes the gesture very clear and gives it room to breathe. There is definitely a bodily aspect to it.

Other moments where we can identify changes in rhythmic grouping occur in the fugue of the Overture, notably in bars 76 and 103, before the following passages begin. These are useful comparisons with the Sarabande, although the rhythmic devices are not identical. It is therefore important to make these shifts audible wherever they recur, rather than letting the continuous motion conceal them.¹³⁰

Figures 17 a-b. Bars 76 and 103¹³¹



¹²⁸ J. S. Bach, French Overture, BWV 831, Sarabande, bars 1–5. Reproduced from Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, 37, ex. 2.40.

¹²⁹ Paul Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, 37, ex. 2.40. The proposed balance and bodily description are my interpretation of the passage.

¹³⁰ Johann Sebastian Bach, *Französische Overture*, BWV 831, in *Klavierübung 2.–4. Teil*, ed. Rudolf Steglich, fingerings by Walther Lampe (Munich–Duisburg: G. Henle Verlag, n.d.), 29 and 31, Overture, bars 76 and 103. The comparison concerns rhythmic regrouping; it does not attribute Badura-Skoda's specific Sarabande analysis to these passages.

¹³¹ J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Overture, passages around bars 76 and 103. Photographs of the author's annotated score, G. Henle Verlag.

Little and Jenne describe the counterpoint of this Sarabande as “seamless” and identify avoided cadences in bars 8 and 16 that sustain the forward movement discussed above.¹³² These are concrete reasons to reconsider a generous pause at an apparent phrase ending. The four-bar model remains a reference, but Bach can frustrate the repose it leads us to expect. If we conscientiously close every four bars, we may find that Bach has already begun the next sentence. Little and Jenne also suggest a mordent on the second beat of the Sarabande’s opening bar and recommend unequal semiquavers where appropriate.¹³³ Their proposed mordent naturally requires some time to be played, not because of technical difficulty but for declamatory reasons. For me, this gives the proposed accent on the second beat a natural and organic feeling rather than a staged one. The small appoggiaturas Bach actually writes in bar 12 require a decision about how to play them. Badura-Skoda describes how Bach is already using a “modern” manner of notating semiquaver appoggiaturas.¹³⁴ He favours a short execution, preferably on the beat, rather than prolonging each appoggiatura into a crotchet.¹³⁵ A crotchet would keep the listener waiting considerably longer for the principal note. His discussion of comparable passing appoggiaturas also makes an important point: whether they are anticipated or played on the beat, the accent should fall on the long notes.¹³⁶

Figure 18.¹³⁷



For the opening of the Sarabande, my working articulation could therefore be sketched as follows:

1 TWO 3 | 1 TWO 3 | 1 2 3 3

This is a reminder of how I hear the gesture in the illustrated passage, rather than a formula for every phrase in the movement.

¹³² Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 112.

¹³³ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 112. The added mordent and unequal semiquavers are their recommendations; the explanation of the mordent’s declamatory effect is my application.

¹³⁴ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 404, ex. 15.35. “Modern” is his description of the small-note notation used in this passage.

¹³⁵ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 404.

¹³⁶ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 403–404, exx. 15.32–15.35. His explicit instruction to place the accent on the long notes occurs in the preceding discussion of passing appoggiaturas in the Italian Concerto; its relevance to this Sarabande is a comparative application.

¹³⁷ J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Sarabande, bars 11–12. Photograph of the author’s annotated score, G. Henle Verlag.

Figure 19. 138



Schulenberg's discussion strengthens the reason for examining this notation closely. He questions the assumption that Bach's small notes should automatically follow the appoggiatura-length rules published by C. P. E. Bach in 1753, pointing to J. S. Bach's distinction between small-note notation and appoggiaturas written in ordinary note values.¹³⁹ This makes bar 12 especially pertinent to an informed reading. The appearance, harmonic function and location of the note matter more than a rule remembered from another treatise.

The Courante presents another relationship between regularity and complication. Little and Jenne describe its two twelve-bar sections as internally organised into 4 + 8 and 6 + 6 bars. They also draw attention to the opening B pedal and to bass rhythms that emphasise preparatory, or arsic, places, an idea returning in bars 20–21.¹⁴⁰

Figures 19a–b.¹⁴¹



¹³⁸ J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Sarabande, opening bars, with the author's annotations showing the proposed grouping.

¹³⁹ David Schulenberg, "Versions of Bach: Performing Practices in the Keyboard Works", in *The Music of J. S. Bach: Analysis and Interpretation*, ed. David Schulenberg, *Bach Perspectives* 4 (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 2024 open-access reprint), 119. Schulenberg illustrates the distinction with the F-sharp-major Prelude, BWV 882; its application here to the Sarabande is my comparison.

¹⁴⁰ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 128; for their use of "arsic", see also 16.

¹⁴¹ J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Courante, opening and bars 20–21. G. Henle Verlag.

The pedal sustains the harmony while the figuration remains rhythmically active. The bass has considerable presence but letting the low register become uniformly heavy would obscure this distinction. Their practical suggestions are unusually specific. Shorten quavers or semiquavers preceding beats 1 and 3, and, where arpeggiation is indicated, spreading the chord from the upper note downwards to preserve the voice-leading.¹⁴² This is something I did not get to try myself, but it would be interesting to experiment with.

The quaver runs on the Courante's third beat could also be subdivided into groups of two instead of slurring all four together, as suggested in the Henle edition. These two lively groups would then prepare the following downbeat. Where appropriate, my articulation could be sketched as follows:¹⁴³

ONE – 2 – 3.3 | ONE – 2 – 3.3

Figure 20.¹⁴⁴



The opening of Gavotte I deserves particular attention here as well. Its half-bar upbeat carries the phrase across the bar line, so the first downbeat arrives within a gesture already under way. Little and Jenne contrast this with the Bourrée's shorter upbeat and its grouping within the bar.¹⁴⁵ At the keyboard, I would first ask where that opening gesture is going before deciding where to lift the hand. For me, the natural weight of the Gavotte falls on the first beat, so a little gap before the downbeat could help make that distinction clear. The appoggiatura in bar 3 could also be treated as a long appoggiatura rather than a short one, with A-sharp receiving time as the dissonant note. This would make the lift more physical, as it were, instead of allowing a short appoggiatura to pass almost unnoticed. It enhances that feeling of coming down, quite literally and physically.¹⁴⁶

¹⁴² Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 128.

¹⁴³ Bach, *Französische Ouverture*, 34–35, Courante. The division of the four quavers into two groups is my proposed articulation, illustrated in the annotated score.

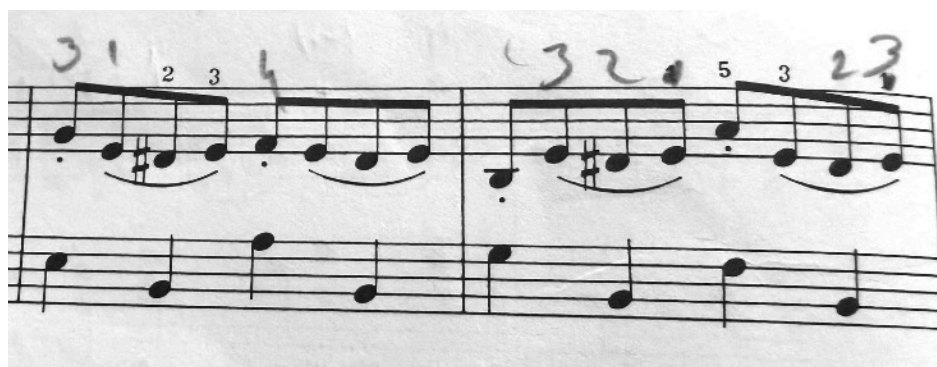
¹⁴⁴ J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Courante, bars 4–5, with my proposed grouping of the quavers.

¹⁴⁵ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 37 and 50–51.

¹⁴⁶ Bach, *Französische Ouverture*, 35, Gavotte I, bar 3. The longer appoggiatura and its physical effect are my proposed execution of the notated dissonance.

Within the Gavottes, BWV 831 gives further reasons to vary the delivery. Note the tiratas in both voices of Gavotte I, its harmonic transitions in bars 12–18 and its move into a higher register in bar 20, where G is its highest melodic note. Gavotte II, in contrast, remains in the lower register; its written-out mordents in bars 13–15 can, if accented at their beginning, produce what Little and Jenne call “jazzy” syncopations against the bass.¹⁴⁷ Here the ornamental figure has a rhythmic consequence. If we smooth it away, the second Gavotte loses some of the mischief that distinguishes it from its companion.

Figure 21.



The Bourrées are an even more pointed pair. Little and Jenne call Bourrée I a “textbook model”, with inequality appropriate to its stepwise passages. Bourrée II, however, begins with three quavers of upbeat and approaches the style of a prelude; they suggest slight fluctuations of the beat to convey its ambiguity.¹⁴⁸ Their shared title does not make identical phrasing obligatory. In this pair, Bach supplies both the convention and a reason to question how strictly it applies. I hear their contrasting characters as inviting much more legato playing in the second Bourrée and a crisper approach in the first, with room to reconsider their tempi as well.

The Passepieds make the harmonic basis of further interpretative decisions particularly clear. Little and Jenne associate Passepiéd I’s opening dissonance and trill with an energetic separation between upbeat and downbeat. In bars 5–6, a hemiola rises over the chromatic bass towards the cadence.¹⁴⁹ These details give the movement its impetus. The same hemiola treatment is particularly clear at the end of this wonderful Passepiéd, where the opening material returns, altered to finish in the appropriate key.¹⁵⁰

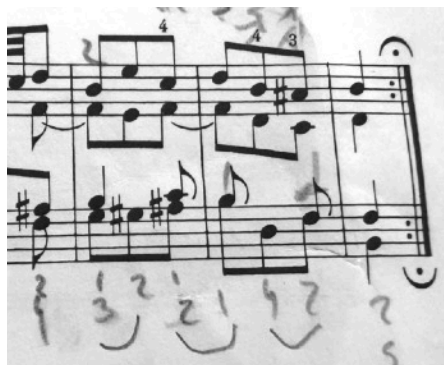
¹⁴⁷ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 60–61; see also Bach, *Französische Ouverture*, 35–36. The word “jazzy” is Little and Jenne’s analogy for the accented ornamental figures.

¹⁴⁸ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 46. The contrasting legato, touch and tempo choices are my interpretative response.

¹⁴⁹ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 91.

¹⁵⁰ Bach, *Französische Ouverture*, 36–37, Passepiéd I, especially bars 30–32; Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 91, describe the final eight bars as an almost literal return of the first strain.

Figure 22.¹⁵¹



Passepied II begins with the upbeat and downbeat on the same harmony, for which Little and Jenne suggest a much smaller separation. Its drone bass evokes the musette, a bagpipe sound, while its phrases are more clearly balanced above this pedal note.¹⁵² The quieter character I associated with Chantilly thus has a musical reference beyond the colour of the garden. Breaking the opening as sharply as in Passepied I would impose a new interruption where Bach has implied a clear connection.

The treatment of the appoggiaturas in bar 6 is quite important as well. Here I would favour a short execution on the beat, giving them that ascending, sighing effect, almost an uplift. The small note takes its time from the principal note, but does not replace it as the centre of the gesture. This is an application of the short-appoggiatura reasoning discussed above, rather than a specific instruction by Badura-Skoda for this bar.¹⁵³ I hear another regrouping in bars 12–14, where the lower parts suggest pairs against the soprano’s descending semiquaver sequence.¹⁵⁴ One more detail concerns the trill endings and the break before the suffix discussed earlier in the Overture. I would also try this in the Passepied, even where a break is not written, to hear whether it suits the gesture. Badura-Skoda’s warning remains relevant: this separated ending is a particular French-style effect, and its use depends on whether the passage can accommodate the interruption.¹⁵⁵

Figure 22a.¹⁵⁶



¹⁵¹ J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Passepied I, bars 30–32. Annotated score, G. Henle Verlag.

¹⁵² Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 91. The association with Chantilly is autobiographical.

¹⁵³ Bach, *Französische Ouverture*, 37, Passepied II, bar 6; compare Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 404. Badura-Skoda’s discussion concerns the Sarabande; the short, on-beat treatment proposed here for the Passepied is my comparison.

¹⁵⁴ Bach, *Französische Ouverture*, 37, Passepied II, bars 12–14. The description of the competing groupings records my reading of the score; compare Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 91, on the movement’s changing groups of quavers and semiquavers.

¹⁵⁵ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 430–431, exx. 16.41–16.43. He describes the halt and separation before the suffix as a particular French-style practice and warns against applying it to flowing, cantabile music. Its use in Passepied II, bars 4 and 19, is my proposal for comparison. See also the preceding discussion and examples in “The Overture: Dotted Rhythm and the Limits of Literal Reading”.

¹⁵⁶ J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Passepied II, bars 6–8. Annotated score, G. Henle Verlag.

Figures 23a–b.¹⁵⁷



The Gigue brings rhythmic character and ornament execution into direct contact. The openings of BWV 813 and BWV 831 show the skipping, *sautillant* figure that Little and Jenne associate with Bach's French giges. They discuss its resemblance to the canarie but retain the distinction between that dance and these two movements.¹⁵⁸ The resemblance identifies a rhythmic family; it does not settle the identity of every member.

Figures 23c–d.¹⁵⁹



Quantz distinguishes a Gigue's "short and light bow-stroke" from the Canarie's "short and sharp one".¹⁶⁰ Badura-Skoda likewise hears BWV 831's Gigue as music that should "skip along" and treats its alternating *Pralltriller* and mordents in relation to detached execution. He admits both an upper-auxiliary beginning and the *Schneller*, judging the former somewhat more brilliant.¹⁶¹ These

¹⁵⁷ J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Passepied II, trill endings in bars 4 and 19, with the proposed separations before the suffix.

¹⁵⁸ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 151–153, especially 152. Their distinction between these giges and true canaries involves phrase organisation and historical interpretation. BWV 831's Gigue is followed by the Echo.

¹⁵⁹ J. S. Bach, French Suite No. 2, BWV 813, Gigue, earlier version, opening; French Overture, BWV 831, Gigue, opening.

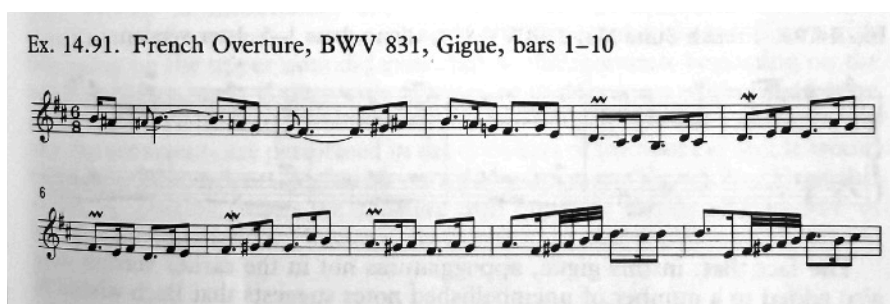
¹⁶⁰ Johann Joachim Quantz, *On Playing the Flute*, ch. XVII, section VII, §58, 291. The instruction concerns bowing; its application to keyboard articulation is a comparison.

¹⁶¹ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 373, exx. 14.91–14.92; see also 114.

alternatives affect how an ornament launches the note and fits the dotted gesture. The tiny sign has become part of the movement's gait.

His account becomes particularly interesting when he describes the "consummate skill with which Bach integrated the ornaments into the melodic and rhythmic structure of a work". In the first two bars, the longer notes delay the motion, and the written appoggiaturas, one from below and one from above, stand in for a mordent and a *Pralltriller*. Even the repetition of a note across the bar line contributes to this opening delay; Bach subsequently avoids that repetition as the movement gets going.¹⁶² The ornaments are therefore already involved in how the theme begins and gathers motion. Adding the same little flourish everywhere would interfere with distinctions Bach has taken the trouble to write.

Figure 24.¹⁶³



Badura-Skoda observes that the later version of BWV 813 adds appoggiaturas before some *Pralltriller* and before some unornamented notes. Their selective presence challenges the assumption that an identical auxiliary-note beginning can simply be supplied everywhere. He also criticises their omission from the Henle and Peters editions he discusses: assuming that a performer will automatically begin on the auxiliary does not explain away the additional notes in the sources.¹⁶⁴ His defence of the *Schneller* in BWV 831 draws on recommendations from around 1750 onwards; it is his argument for a feasible execution, rather than an instruction printed by Bach in 1735.¹⁶⁵ The following page supplies a useful comparison with Variation 7 of the Goldberg Variations. There, Badura-Skoda questions the rhythmic asymmetry produced by beginning mordents on the main note but *Pralltriller* on the upper auxiliary. He favours a three-note execution of both in that example.¹⁶⁶ His objection gives me something concrete to listen for in the Gigue.

¹⁶² Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 373–374. The quotation and discussion concern the integration of the opening appoggiaturas and repeated notes into BWV 831's Gigue theme.

¹⁶³ Contrasting ornament executions and related Gigue writing. Reproduced from Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, 373–374, ex. 14.91

¹⁶⁴ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 374, ex. 14.93. He discusses the later embellished version of BWV 813 and the omission of its appoggiaturas from the editions he names. His account identifies manuscript copies supporting their presence; those manuscript sources are cited here through his discussion.

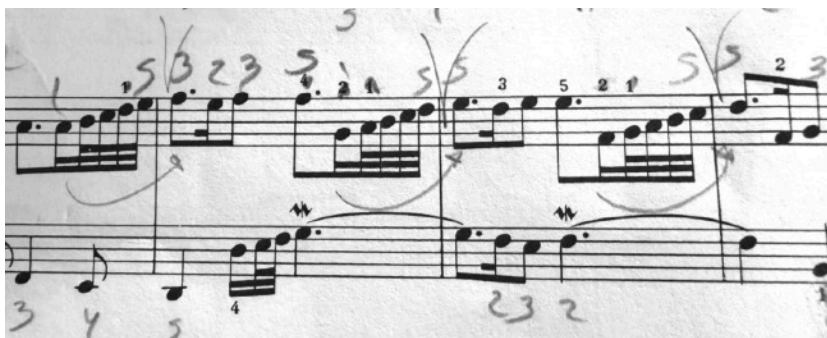
¹⁶⁵ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 373. He associates the *Schneller* recommendation with staccato figuration from about 1750 onwards.

¹⁶⁶ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 375, exx. 14.94–14.96. His discussion concerns Variation 7 of the Goldberg Variations; the question posed here about BWV 831 is my interpretative comparison.

Another interesting feature of this Gigue, compared with the Gigue of French Suite No. 2, is the prominent use of *tiratas* throughout the movement, especially in the second part. Little and Jenne describe these runs as filling out the *sautillant* figure and being particularly effective in the drive towards the final cadence.¹⁶⁷ They give the Gigue an even more buoyant and effusive character, almost like fireworks. The rumble they generate on the harpsichord would be particularly effective in terms of colour.

Their execution, however, could easily cause a few finger stumbles. My teacher, Mei-Ting Sun, suggested treating these *tiratas* almost as a run separate from the arrival note, allowing a small jump before the downbeat. The dotted note can be slightly prolonged, almost as though double-dotted, and the run played in one motion, rather like strumming the strings of a guitar. In the ascending right-hand passages illustrated below, using fingers 1 to 5 and then reusing finger 5 on the arrival avoids a turn that would take away some of the character. Similarly, in the left hand, the five-finger run can lead from thumb to thumb on the arrival.¹⁶⁸ A clever and well-chosen fingering is essential here: the hand has to make the run sound like one gesture.

Figures 25a-b.¹⁶⁹



Nor does a skipping melody make every other voice a permanently obedient accompaniment; the two voices actively interact. Little and Jenne identify the bass's more assertive role at bar 36 of BWV

¹⁶⁷ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 153.

¹⁶⁸ Mei-Ting Sun, advice given during my piano lessons, personal communication. The description records my account of the suggested fingering and execution; it is not presented as a historical fingering prescribed by Bach.

¹⁶⁹ J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Gigue, selected *tirata* passages, including bars 24-27 and 40-41. Annotated score showing the proposed fingering.

831's Gigue, and the tiratas contributing to the drive towards its final cadence.¹⁷⁰ Maintaining the same hierarchy throughout would miss a change the music has earned.

Finally, we have a very unusual movement, and a tricky one to execute on the harpsichord. The Echo involves constant movement between manuals, through which Bach creates its answering effects. Badura-Skoda specifically remarks on the demands these rapid changes place on the harpsichordist, while Norell describes the quick succession of quiet interjections and returns to the stronger manual.¹⁷¹ This becomes particularly important when transferring the movement to the piano, a subject taken up in the next chapter.

One of the technical difficulties is that the changes between *piano* and *forte* occur in awkward places: on weak parts of the bar, within a figure, or on the second semiquaver rather than neatly at the beginning of a new bar. This creates the effect of interruption and buoyancy.¹⁷² Badura-Skoda's example of bars 58–62 is useful here because it connects the graphic grouping of the notes with the changes of manual. The breaks are part of the articulation of the material, even when the playing remains legato.¹⁷³ The quieter reply can arrive before the previous gesture seems quite ready to give up the floor.

Bars 22, 24, 54 and 56 show another musical resource Bach uses here: ascending and descending broken chords fill the space with sound. I hear them almost as explosions, particularly when they follow the quieter runs.¹⁷⁴ This is striking when one is accustomed to following Bach's continuous counterpoint: here the contrast of sound itself demands attention.

Figures 26a-b¹⁷⁵



¹⁷⁰ Little and Jenne, *Dance and the Music of J. S. Bach*, 153. Their numbering excludes the upbeat; see 34.

¹⁷¹ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 139; Luke Norell, *Interpreting Bach's Overture after the French Manner on the Modern Piano* (DM diss., Indiana University, 2014), 28. Both discuss the Echo's rapid manual changes; the response to their transfer onto the piano is my observation.

¹⁷² Bach, *Französische Ouverture*, 43–44, Echo. The description concerns the placement of the contrasting passages within its 2/4 bars.

¹⁷³ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 128, ex. 4.79, Echo, bars 58–62. He relates the graphic grouping and the breaks to changes of manual.

¹⁷⁴ Bach, *Französische Ouverture*, 43–44, Echo, especially bars 22–25 and 54–57. The description of the broken chords as explosions, and of the movement as a study in sound effects, is my listening response.

¹⁷⁵ J. S. Bach, BWV 831, Echo, bars 54–57 and 23–25. Annotated score, G. Henle Verlag.

Also note the *forte* indication in the lower part while the right hand plays its *piano* run. This feels counterintuitive at the piano, where the left hand may instinctively follow the right into a softer sound. On the harpsichord, however, the left hand can remain on the stronger manual while the right changes to the quieter one. The difference between the hands is therefore already available through their placement. The octave writing also stands out in these passages, adding weight below the lighter upper line. More than anything, I hear the Echo as a study in these sorts of Baroque sound effects.

Listening Bac(h)k

Performance, Recording and Musical Choice

Recording myself has always been rather difficult for me. I am hardly ever completely satisfied with a take. Everything goes well except one small accent; in the next take, the accent comes out well, but everything else goes wrong. It can be a frustrating process. I have also never liked having to choose just one way of playing when there are several I would like to keep.

For me, editing is not immoral. If combining takes helps me reach the musical result I want, I use it. Playing live is another experience. I think of the performer as a bullfighter in front of the bull; one wrong step, and the audience knows what could happen. There is that adrenaline, but also a real connection with the people listening. I value it. Trying to imitate it in the studio, however, seems to miss the point of recording.

Gould had little patience with the accusation that splicing was dishonest or destroyed the unity of a performance. He writes that “one cannot ever splice style”: the passages still need to belong together musically. He also allows for the “posttaping reconsideration of performance”.¹⁷⁶ This interested me because the decision can come after hearing what one has played.

His A-minor fugue, BWV 865, is a good example. Of eight takes, numbers 6 and 8 were considered satisfactory. Weeks later, both sounded monotonous. One was solemn and legato; the other, predominantly staccato, was too consistently lively. Since their tempos were almost identical, he could combine them: the more imposing take for the opening and ending, the livelier one for the

¹⁷⁶ Glenn Gould, “The Prospects of Recording,” in *The Glenn Gould Reader*, ed. Tim Page (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1989), 337–338. The essay was originally published in 1966.

episodes.¹⁷⁷ Both takes had seemed good enough in the studio. Listening afterwards changed his mind.

Cook also questions why we judge a recording as though it were an inferior version of a concert.¹⁷⁸ Listening to my own takes, I am interested in which version convinces me when I hear it again, including those that felt less convincing to play.

I deliberately recorded before doing the detailed reading for this essay. I wanted to hear what I could do with the resources I already had, many of them intuitive. Cook questions the idea that analysis must lead directly to a particular performance.¹⁷⁹ My order was the reverse. I would not claim to be fully informed now, but certainly more informed than before. Nelson accepts retrospective enquiry, provided that examining the practice brings out demonstrable insights.¹⁸⁰ In my case, this meant comparing my choices and keeping even the less successful attempts to see what they revealed about my habits.

At first, I associated French style with a certain rigidity. I wanted to explore how much freedom I could take. Badura-Skoda quotes an account of Bach conducting at generally fast but very steady tempos, something that appeals to my own preference for playing quickly. Yet his “firm ‘pillars’ of the beats” leave room to move between them. He gives a practical example: breathing between a tutti and the following solo passage, even in keyboard music, without making a ritardando.¹⁸¹

Using the accompanying website

At french-overture.vercel.app, *Home* introduces the project. In *Laboratory*, choose a movement, section and version. Most movements have A and B sections; the Overture separates introduction, fugue and return. The codes identify the examples above. *My Versions* contains my assembled interpretations; *Gallery*, the visual references; *Library*, the essay and bibliographical resources; and *About Me*, personal background. Revisiting a passage across takes allows the listener to compare the decisions discussed here.

¹⁷⁷ Gould, “The Prospects of Recording,” 338–339. Gould describes combining takes 6 and 8 of the A-minor fugue from the first book of *The Well-Tempered Clavier*, BWV 865. The account of the recording and editing process is his own.

¹⁷⁸ Nicholas Cook, *Beyond the Score: Music as Performance* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), 353–355. Cook examines the hierarchy that treats recordings as copies of live performance and the competing expectations surrounding repetition, editing and continuity. The account of listening to my own takes is autobiographical.

¹⁷⁹ Cook, *Beyond the Score*, 42, 47–48. Cook questions a one-way mapping from analysis to performance; the retrospective ordering of this project is my application of the argument.

¹⁸⁰ Robin Nelson, *Practice as Research in the Arts (and Beyond): Principles, Processes, Contexts, Achievements*, 2nd ed. (Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2022), 38–39. Nelson permits retrospective enquiry when practice is investigative and yields demonstrable insights; he explicitly rejects treating every instance of practice as research after the event.

¹⁸¹ Paul Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach at the Keyboard*, 16–17. The account of Bach’s conducting is cited through Badura-Skoda, who identifies its source as the *Nekrolog* in *Bach-Dokumente*, III, 87. On p. 17 he distinguishes regular beat from motoric rigidity and discusses breathing between tutti and solo passages, including in solo keyboard music.

Comentary on a Selection of Recordings

In OUV-A-V2, approximately ♩ = 50–55, I play it more thoughtfully. It does not announce the king's majestic arrival; I imagine a past reign, perhaps forgotten. The sound can be quite effective, although the alla-breve movement has its limitations. OUV-A-V3, at approximately ♩ = 77, is perhaps my closest attempt to what we discussed earlier. The movement in two is clear, and the ornaments and tiratas have something improvisatory about them. Even at this tempo, the dotted notes leave space before the downbeat. I find this version more convincing. I also separate the suffix and articulate the left hand in bars 6 and 10–12. Badura-Skoda discusses the break before the suffix in French-style pieces, while warning against using it everywhere.¹⁸²

In COU-A-V2, I try to show the rhythmic movement we discussed, almost hurrying from the third beat into the first. I give particular attention to the opening pedal notes and make small variations in bar 8. In COU-A-V3, I experiment with notes inégales throughout. They are not really dotted quavers; it is more a triplet-like feeling. I particularly like this version. In COU-B-V2, I add appoggiaturas or passing notes and extra notes to the arpeggios. There is inequality in bar 20, more mordents and turns, and more varied, contrasting dynamics.

GAV1-A-V2 is a version I like and find convincing. I feel the physical weight of the dance on the downbeat, especially with the mf–f sound. The mordents and subdivisions are clear, with a detached left hand and quite a lot of weight in the touch. GAV1-A-V3 has more freedom in the tempo. The main beats remain clear, but between them I feel a back-and-forth movement that works quite well, with dynamics moving between mp, p and mf. In GAV2-A-V2, I bring out the short-short-long movement in the left hand and linger a little on the downbeat. The right hand is more cantabile, with extended ornaments and an mp sound.

In PAS1-A-V1, the tempo is slow, controlled and steady, with dynamics mainly in p and pp. The ornaments and left hand are clear, with a sotto-voce sound and a translucent upper voice. It may seem counterintuitive for this dance, but I find it very effective in sound. PAS1-B-V4 is faster and lighter, with quick runs, short ornaments and less breathing on the third beat before the downbeat. SAR-A-V1, at approximately ♩ = 34, is much slower than usual, almost to the point of discomfort. It is thoughtful, but loses some of the dance impulse. In SAR-A-V3, at ♩ = 45, I try to show the movement of the four-bar phrase, with a steady tempo and an mp, cantabile sound.

GIG-A-V4 is my closest attempt at the skipping character we discussed. Both voices are detached, unlike other takes where one is detached and the other legato. I also distinguish the ornaments

¹⁸² Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 430–431. He discusses the break before the written trill suffix in the French Overture and expressly warns against generalising it to flowing, cantabile pieces. The descriptions and evaluations of the recordings in this chapter are my own; metronome figures are approximate values from my notes.

discussed by Badura-Skoda, with a lively mf sound.¹⁸³ In ECH-B-V2, I make the dynamic terraces very clear, with weight but also forward movement. I take a little time for the quieter echoes. Even though I am not changing manuals on the piano, I feel I need that space for the echo to be heard. Norell also points out that changing manuals changes the colour as well as the volume.¹⁸⁴

Some Thoughts to Finish...

This has been an interesting and enriching experience, and one that has brought me back down to earth. It has made me reconsider things I learned throughout my training, including ideas I had accepted so readily that I no longer thought about them when playing.

In several places, I found that my choices were not so far from what the authors recommended. That was reassuring. I feel I was guided by the right people, and that much of what they taught me had stayed with me, even when I could not have explained where it came from.

It also made me realise how easily something learned can become something automatic. A useful piece of advice settles into a habit, and eventually I stop asking whether it suits the passage in front of me. I want to pay more attention to that.

My trip to France also gave the work's French reference something tangible. The rooms at Versailles, the gardens of Chantilly and the artworks I saw became part of how I imagined the music. Their colours, spaces and gestures stayed with me when I came to record it.

The laboratory showed me how many decisions remain possible within one work. With so much written about Bach and style, one might expect the task to become fairly straightforward. Bach is far too inventive for that. There are things in his music I can hear and feel without quite knowing how to explain them.

I may never arrive at a definitive version. Studying the style and experimenting give me more tools with which to make my choices. That has been the most rewarding part; having more to listen for and more to try, including in music I thought I already knew.

¹⁸³ Badura-Skoda, *Interpreting Bach*, 373–374. His discussion concerns detached articulation and the different ornaments in the Gigue of BWV 831; the judgement about GIG-A-V4 is my own.

¹⁸⁴ Norell, "Interpreting Bach's Overture," 31. Norell discusses changes of colour as well as volume between harpsichord manuals and the pianist's task of recreating these contrasts. Allowing time for the quieter response is my interpretative decision, not a historical requirement asserted by Norell.

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